

The Ānāpānasati Sutta: A Path to Awakening

*Developing Calm and Insight through Mindfulness of
Breathing Meditation*



By Bhante Gunaratana

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Reading the References

The references use DN for Dīgha Nikāya, the long discourses; MN for Majjhima Nikāya, the middle-length discourses; SN for Saṃyutta Nikāya, the connected discourses; and AN for Aṅguttara Nikāya, the numerical discourses. Sn refers to Sutta Nipāta, and Khp to Khuddakapāṭha. The section sign (§) marks a paragraph; §§ marks several paragraphs. Publication details and a list of canonical references appear at the end of the book.

Forward

This book grew out of a series of lectures that Bhante Henepola Gunaratana, known to many as Bhante G, gave over Zoom in 2023. It presents his teaching on mindfulness of breathing, the practice of attending to each in-breath and out-breath. Practitioners can return to these teachings as their understanding and experience develop. The book offers clear guidance, encouragement, and practical help with the work of meditation.

At the heart of the book are the sixteen instructions of the *Ānāpānasati Sutta*, the Buddha's discourse on mindfulness of breathing. Beginning with awareness of breathing, the teaching explores the body, feeling, the mind, and the understanding that leads toward freedom from suffering. Tranquility, the calming and steadying of the mind, develops together with insight, the clear seeing of experience as it is. As attention becomes steadier, the changing nature of experience becomes easier to recognize, and that recognition helps us loosen our attachment to it.

The book retains the direct, conversational tone of Bhante G's lectures. Familiar illustrations, direct questions, and repeated reminders bring attention back to the practice itself. The questions discussed here will be recognizable to many meditators: how to work with wandering thoughts, how to respond to obstacles in meditation, how to balance effort, and how to understand the experiences that arise as the mind settles. The explanations invite careful observation and patient practice.

The training unfolds gradually. A passage that seems clear on a first reading may reveal more after a period of meditation. Readers may find it helpful to pause over an instruction, explore it in practice, and then return to the explanation. The same care can extend into ordinary activities, including how we listen, speak, and respond to others.

This book is offered in the hope that it will help practitioners establish a steady practice and continue with confidence and understanding. May its guidance support a deeper familiarity with the breath, greater kindness toward ourselves and others, and a growing capacity to meet daily life with mindfulness.

Chapter 1

Mindfulness of Breathing



People have long used the breath as an object of meditation. They may hear various instructions about focusing the mind on the breath and develop all kinds of ideas about it. These practitioners are sincere in their efforts, but most of their ideas about meditation are mistaken. They keep trying to practice but sometimes become totally confused. It is better to understand the Buddha's teachings directly.

Mindfulness means being aware of what is happening with clear understanding. I have heard all kinds of stories from people who say they attain liberation as soon as they sit down to meditate. Complete liberation, or full enlightenment, means complete freedom from greed, hatred, and delusion—the failure to see things as they really are. Mindfulness of breathing is a profound and complex practice. All the Buddhas practiced mindfulness of breathing to attain full enlightenment. Claims of immediate liberation

oversimplify the practice. On the other hand, some people find it extremely difficult because they don't know how to practice it.¹

A verse attributed to the elder Mahākappina says that one who fully develops mindfulness of breathing according to the Buddha's teaching illuminates the world like the full moon freed from clouds. Through this practice, that person's own life begins to shine.²

It is also said that one whose mindfulness of breathing is both developed and perfected remains quite settled and steady in body and mind. Therefore, this is a very important subject that we must learn very carefully and mindfully.³

Why Give Time to the Practice

We can spend a great deal of energy improving our circumstances and still feel that something is missing. An achievement brings relief, but that relief changes. Once the goal has been achieved, another desire appears. We try to maintain pleasant experiences, push away painful ones, and pass over what seems uninteresting. Much of life disappears into these habits before we have really understood it.

Meditation asks us to examine that activity of the mind. We set aside time to practice because neither distraction nor acquiring things can put an end to dissatisfaction. The change we seek is in how we meet experience, even when we cannot arrange it to suit ourselves. As awareness develops, the habits of grasping, resisting, and overlooking become easier to recognize. Then we have the opportunity to loosen their hold. The work

¹ For the traditional account, see Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, VIII.155.

² Theragāthā 548, in the verses of Mahākappina (10.3); see also Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, VIII.203.

³ SN 54.7, "Kappina."

takes persistence. Its purpose is a mind less burdened by its own reactions, with more room for peace and care for others.⁴

The Buddha's Teaching

On the full-moon day at the end of the three-month rainy season, the Buddha found monks sitting and meditating. Some senior monks were instructing groups of ten, twenty, thirty, or forty monks. They taught mindfulness of breathing and the thirty-seven factors of enlightenment—the qualities that support awakening.

The monks were doing quite well. On the next full-moon day, they were meditating very seriously and quietly. The Buddha was very pleased. Then he instructed them in mindfulness of breathing. Developing mindfulness of breathing develops the four foundations of mindfulness: mindfulness of the body, feelings, mind, and mental objects—what the mind knows. As these develop, so do the seven factors of enlightenment, leading to knowledge and liberation. These seven are mindfulness, awareness of what is happening; investigation of Dhamma, examining the phenomena we experience; energy, the effort to practice; joy, uplifting gladness; tranquility, calm of body and mind; concentration, gathered and steady attention; and equanimity, mental balance. This is the setting of the *Ānāpānasati* (Mindfulness of Breathing) Sutta.⁵

The gathering took place in the Eastern Park at Sāvattthī, in the residence associated with Migāra's mother. Among the senior disciples were Sāriputta, Mahāmoggallāna, Mahākassapa, and Ānanda. When monks elsewhere heard that the Buddha would remain until the following full moon, they came to see him.

⁴ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, chap. 1.

⁵ MN 118.

The assembly included monks who had completed the path and others at earlier stages of awakening. Some cultivated the foundations of mindfulness, others the awakening factors or the noble eightfold path. This path consists of right view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, mindfulness, and concentration. They also practiced loving-friendliness, wishing beings well; compassion, wishing them freedom from suffering; appreciative joy, rejoicing in their happiness; and equanimity, keeping the mind balanced. Contemplating the body's unattractive features and perceiving impermanence, the changing nature of experience, were also among their practices. Mindfulness of breathing was being developed within this varied community, where those with experience helped those still learning.⁶

There is also an account of the Buddha teaching mindfulness of breathing after monks had misunderstood contemplation of the body's unattractive aspects. Instead of gaining a clear understanding of the body, they became overwhelmed by revulsion. Some took their own lives, and others asked to be killed. When the Buddha returned from retreat and learned what had happened, he gathered the monks and taught mindfulness of breathing. This was a different occasion from the gathering described in the *Ānāpānasati Sutta*. It reminds us why understanding the purpose of a meditation is so important.⁷

In the *Ānāpānasati Sutta*, the Buddha said that when mindfulness of breathing is developed and cultivated, all four foundations of mindfulness are practiced and completed: mindfulness of the body, feelings, mind, and mental objects, dhamma. Feeling may be pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Although we practice only mindfulness

⁶ MN 118, §§1–14.

⁷ SN 54.9.

of breathing, all four foundations are compressed into it. We must decompress this teaching to understand how one practice develops or includes all four foundations.⁸

Along with the four foundations of mindfulness, this practice develops the seven factors of enlightenment and the noble eightfold path. All the Buddhas and enlightened persons attain the highest state by practicing mindfulness of breathing. That is why it is such a profound subject.

The Sixteen Steps

The sixteen instructions come in four groups of four, called tetrads, corresponding to the four foundations of mindfulness. Each instruction includes breathing in and breathing out. Let us see the whole practice before looking at the details. With the body, we know long breathing and short breathing, experience the whole body of breath from beginning to end, and tranquilize the bodily formations—the inhalation and exhalation.

With feeling, we experience rapture, or joy; experience pleasure; experience mental formations; and tranquilize these formations. Here, the term mental formations refers to feeling and perception. Perception is how we recognize what we experience. We learn to know them as we breathe and allow them to become calm.

With the mind, we experience the mind, gladden it, concentrate it, and liberate it. We know the mind with its contents. As harmful, or unwholesome, states fade, the mind becomes glad and gains concentration. We learn to free it from greed, hatred, delusion, and other unwholesome states.

With mental objects, or what the mind knows, we contemplate impermanence, fading away, cessation, and relinquishment. We see things arise and pass away, notice their

⁸ MN 118, §15 and §§23–44.

fading and ceasing, and learn to let go. Together, these four groups show the breadth of mindfulness of breathing. The complete Pali and English instructions are collected at the end of the book in “The Sixteen Steps in Review.”⁹

Tranquility and Insight

Mindfulness of breathing develops both tranquility and insight. Tranquility calms and steadies the mind; insight allows us to see experience as it is. The Buddha taught them as two aspects of Buddhist meditation, like two sides of the same coin. We must not think that he taught only one or the other, or regard them as separate subjects. We must practice mindfulness of breathing carefully and with understanding.

When you see the impermanence of everything, you practice mindfulness. You see the impermanence of your eyes, ears, nose, tongue, and body; of sights, sounds, smells, tastes, touches, and mind objects; and of your feelings, perceptions, and so forth. All of this is constantly changing, as are your breath, the environment, and the temperature.

As you develop the perception that everything is impermanent, no object can excite you, depress you, or make you unhappy. You see that all these experiences are alike in being impermanent. Seeing this, you gain concentration and become equanimous.

Equanimity is a part of concentration. Jhānas are states of deep concentration. In the fourth jhāna, in particular, both equanimity and mindfulness are purified.

Tranquility and insight develop together naturally when you practice mindfulness of breathing exactly as the Buddha has explained. You don’t have to make a special effort to combine them. Practicing in this way, you cannot go wrong.

⁹ MN 118, §§18–21.

We can begin to understand how these work together in an ordinary sitting. Suppose you are aware of the breath touching the nostrils. At first you notice only a little of the inhalation before the mind wanders. You return, and gradually you remain aware of more of the breath. The body begins to settle. There is less need to keep pulling the mind back. This steadiness gives you an opportunity to look more closely.

What do you notice? One breath is long, and another is shorter. A touch that seemed continuous has a beginning and an end. Even the quietness of the mind changes. Concentration helps attention remain with the experience; mindfulness notices what is happening within it. The breath does not have to become motionless for the mind to become steady.

Then perhaps you want the calm to stay exactly as it is. A little impatience arises when the next breath feels different. You can become aware of that, too. The wish to keep an experience is happening now, just as the breath is. Recognizing that wish gives you an opportunity to let go and continue breathing with less struggle.

Friends, we do not need to call this brief experience an attainment. We are learning how to practice. Remaining with the breath helps us see its changes, and seeing those changes helps us release the demand that the breath and the mind obey our wishes. We continue patiently, allowing steadiness and understanding to develop together.¹⁰

¹⁰ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 14, “Mindfulness Versus Concentration.”

Chapter 2

Making Room for Practice



To make the practice more effective, we must avoid certain things that disturb it.

In the Mindfulness of Breathing Discourse, the Buddha explains the importance of choosing a secluded place for practice, such as an empty hut or the foot of a tree.

Traditional guidance also recommends a place away from marketplaces and wells where people gather to gossip.¹¹

These days, complete silence may be difficult to find, but we can still choose a relatively quiet place. Even our own room is suitable when we have it to ourselves.

¹¹ MN 118, §17; for the traditional discussion of a suitable location, see Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, IV.1–18 and VIII.155.

We must avoid prolonged talking and the company of people who are not practicing meditation. We need to eat moderately and choose a suitable place and climate. Our posture should be steady, making us neither too uncomfortable nor too lazy.

To practice effectively, we must also have the skills traditionally required of a meditator. One is keeping the base clean. This means keeping the immediate surroundings clean: the seat, the floor, and the cushions. There should be no dust, insects or creeping creatures, or rough objects such as thorns and rocks.

We must also keep the body clean. Otherwise, itching may disturb the practice. Our most immediate environment is the body, followed by our clothes. If the clothes are not clean, they can make us uncomfortable.¹²

We sit comfortably, rest our hands in our lap, close our eyes, and keep the body upright, without moving back and forth. This allows us to breathe comfortably and fill our lungs with air, giving us the oxygen we need to stay awake.

We must also remember that awareness is always ready. As the body becomes steady and quiet, so does the mind. Mentality and materiality—mind and body—always go together.

To attend to tension, begin with what you actually feel. Suppose you sit down and notice that your shoulders are held up tightly. You may have been rushing from one task to another. Now you notice tightness or pulling in the shoulders. Give attention to that experience. There is no need to begin by tracing everything that happened during the day or deciding who made you tense.

¹² Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, IV.35–44.

Check how you are sitting. If you are holding your shoulders up or keeping your arms rigid, let them rest more comfortably. Make an adjustment with awareness when it is needed. Then notice what is present. Has the tightness eased? Is some still there? Attend to what you feel now, rather than assuming that the adjustment must have removed it.

The sensation and your response to it are different things. The shoulders may feel tight, and the mind may complain, “This is taking too long. I should be calm by now.” The complaint directs you into thoughts about how the sitting ought to be. Recognize that impatience. You can know that tension is present without adding a judgment about the whole meditation period.

For example, you may remember how easily you settled yesterday. Today you keep comparing this sitting with that one. While doing so, you scarcely notice the shoulders at all. You are thinking about tension rather than attending to it. Let the comparison go and return to the bodily experience. You need not describe it to yourself in a long series of words.

Nor does attending mean waiting impatiently for a particular result. You might notice some easing and immediately start asking whether all the tension has gone. That question can take over the sitting. Give yourself time to observe. If the sensation changes, know the change. If tightness remains, acknowledge that too. We are learning to recognize experience clearly, and that includes recognizing the wish to make it different.

When you feel more at ease and can attend to the breath, turn your attention to breathing. You need not keep checking the shoulders to make sure they remain exactly as

they were. You have attended to the tension that was prominent. Now let the breath become your subject and know it as it comes in and goes out.¹³

We must also take care of our conduct. What we say and do affects the mind we bring to meditation. When we act harmfully, regret can disturb us as soon as we sit down. Keeping our conduct clean helps us settle the mind.

For laypeople, this training includes five precepts. We undertake to refrain from killing, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, and taking intoxicants. By keeping these precepts, we restrain harmful actions and speech and support the work we do in meditation. We practice this restraint while continuing to develop the mind.

Suppose someone at work asks about a mistake. You know you made it, but you are embarrassed and say that another person was responsible. The conversation ends, and you go back to your work. Later, when you sit to meditate, you remember what you said. You may wonder whether the other person will be blamed or whether somebody will discover the truth. Your room is quiet, but the mind is occupied with that conversation.

You may even begin preparing another explanation. You want to correct what you said without admitting that you were dishonest. Notice how much work this gives the mind. One statement has led to several more that you have not even spoken. While you are arranging them, you have lost touch with the breath. You wanted to avoid an uncomfortable moment, and now you are carrying that moment into your meditation.

Seeing this, you can acknowledge the mistake honestly. There is no need to keep defending it to yourself. If you can correct the false impression, resolve to do so at an

¹³ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 10, “Dealing with Problems,” “Problem 1: Physical Pain.”

appropriate time. Then give your attention to the practice. When the opportunity comes, make the correction. Otherwise, you may sit down the following day and begin the same argument with yourself again.

Now consider the same situation before the lie is spoken. Someone asks about the mistake, and you feel embarrassed. You can admit what happened and attend to what needs to be done. There may still be an unpleasant conversation. Someone may be disappointed. But you have not added a false account that you must remember and protect. You can see the difference between dealing with the original mistake and creating another difficulty through your response.

This is something to examine in your own daily life. Notice the occasions when you are tempted to conceal a fault, take something that is not yours, or hurt somebody in return for an injury. Those are occasions to practice restraint. Do not postpone all your training until you reach the meditation seat. Begin with the next thing you say or do, and continue when you sit down to attend to the breath.¹⁴

Company and Commitment

Some people don't like to meditate. They like to hear about it, read a book, and discuss it. They say, "We are all right. We don't have to meditate. We are calm. We are peaceful. We have loving-friendliness. We don't hurt anybody. We don't commit any offenses. Therefore, we are all right. We don't have to meditate." They pose the greatest danger to meditation because they disturb the meditator. We must try to avoid them as far as possible.

¹⁴ Gunaratana, *The Jhanas in Theravada Buddhist Meditation*, chap. 2, "The Moral Foundation for Jhana."

We must associate with people who love practicing meditation and developing concentration. Sharing a similar attitude and practice helps us encourage one another. If a husband meditates, the wife should also meditate so that together they can make a schedule for work and meditation. People who live with friends must share a similar attitude, with everyone taking an interest in the practice of meditation.

Then we resolve to keep up our practice at a regular time.

Choose a period that you can keep on an ordinary day. Morning may suit you, before the day's work begins. Evening may be more practical. Whichever you choose, allow enough time to be reasonably awake and ready to practice. Decide approximately how long you will sit before you begin. Start with a manageable period and increase it gradually as the practice develops.

Suppose you plan to meditate before leaving for work. You already know when you must leave and what needs to be done beforehand. Make room for meditation when arranging those things. If you leave the decision until the morning, you may find yourself doing one small task after another. Then you look at the time and say that there is no opportunity to sit. The period you intended for practice has been used for other things.

Perhaps you share your home with people who need your attention. Let them know when you intend to meditate, and make a reasonable arrangement together. This gives practical meaning to supporting one another. If you agree to take care of something afterward, take care of it. It is easier to keep a regular practice when we have made room for it among our responsibilities.

Once you sit down, use the period for practice. Constantly checking how many minutes remain only gives the mind another occupation. There is no special duration that

guarantees concentration. A long sitting is not an achievement merely because it is long. What matters is the attention you bring to the practice and your willingness to keep learning.

One morning, you may notice the breath quite clearly. The next morning, your mind may return repeatedly to something you have to do at work. Do not make a rule that you will meditate only on mornings when the mind is already quiet. On the busy morning, you can recognize that you are thinking about work and attend to breathing again. You are practicing with the mind as it is that morning.

If your circumstances change, look at the arrangement and adjust it sensibly. A change in your working hours may require a different sitting time. Decide on the new time instead of leaving the practice indefinitely until life becomes less busy. If you wait until everything else is finished, you may keep postponing the practice.¹⁵

Putting Aside the Impediments

There are ten impediments, or obstacles, that make it difficult to settle the mind and give our attention to the breath.¹⁶

The first obstacle is the dwelling place. If there is work to do around your home, your mind will turn to it when you sit to meditate: “I have not finished such-and-such. I have not cleaned my bedroom. I have not done my laundry. I have to do some repairs to the wall or roof or plumbing,” and so on. These things should be put out of your mind temporarily.

¹⁵ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 8, “Structuring Your Meditation,” “When To Sit” and “How Long To Sit.”

¹⁶ For the traditional list of ten impediments, see Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, III.29–56.

The second is family: family obligations, errands, visits, responsibilities, and relatives. We need to take care of these concerns or temporarily put them out of our minds.

The third is gain: expecting to gain various things in business, in relationships, and so forth. The fourth is people and meetings. We think of attending such-and-such a meeting—a family meeting, a community meeting, a school meeting, a political meeting, and so on. Put these out of your mind. The fifth is work: office work, social work, and various other types of work. That makes five: dwelling place, family, gain, meetings, and work.

The sixth obstacle is travel. If you have various places to visit, your mind will go there, planning trips, flights, hotel stays, or even a walk.

The seventh is relatives and our obligations to them. Someone in our family may be sick. An elderly parent may need our help. We should attend to these responsibilities with care. Otherwise, we may sit down to meditate and spend the whole time worrying about what we have left undone. We do what we can and, when necessary, arrange for someone else to help. Then, when we sit down, we can remind ourselves, “For now, I have done what I can.” We allow these concerns to rest and give our attention to the breath.

Sickness is the eighth obstacle. When you are sick, paying attention to your breath, gaining concentration, and noticing the various stages of breathing will be very difficult because your mind turns to the sickness. Therefore, when you are sick, wait until you get well to meditate.

The ninth obstacle is study. You may be reading a Dhamma book—a book on the Buddha’s teaching—or a secular book, or doing schoolwork. Reading, learning, memorizing, writing, and so forth can all occupy the mind.

Supernatural powers are the tenth obstacle. Many meditators think they can fly in the air as soon as they start meditating! Recently, somebody came here and said that one day a supernatural being had taken them away and put them in an apartment for four months. I expressed my doubt about that statement. But the person said to me several times, “Yes, Bhante, you don’t believe it. This really happened.”

If you believe in those things and try to meditate, your practice will become very difficult. Therefore, put them aside until the end of your meditation; don’t bring them in at the beginning. Don’t think that you can fly in the air as soon as you sit to meditate. You can sink into the ground with sleepiness, not fly in the air!

All these things are called impediments or obstacles to your meditation.

Recognizing the Hindrances

In addition to these obstacles, there are eight hindrances—mental states that obstruct meditation—that we need to overcome during our practice.¹⁷

The first is desire, or greed. Desire for things we have seen, heard, smelled, tasted, and touched before will come to mind. We may remember people, places, animals, various kinds of conversations, sounds, music, and songs—all kinds of things we have experienced. Or you may think about what you will see, hear, smell, taste, and touch soon after meditation. You want these experiences, and that desire becomes an obstacle.

¹⁷ *Paṭisambhidāmagga*, Treatise III, “On Breathing,” §§2–5, in Ñāṇamoli, *The Path of Discrimination*, 200–201.

Therefore, breathe in and out mindfully. Focus on the breath, without allowing these desires to distract you. This can be difficult: sleepiness or distracting thoughts may arise and obstruct concentration.

The second is anger, hatred, or resentment. As soon as they sit down to meditate, many meditators remember something somebody has done to them, and anger arises. Somebody hurt you, hurt your relatives, or supported your enemy. When you remember these things, you get angry, and that is an obstacle.

The third is sleepiness and drowsiness. This is very difficult to overcome. You fall asleep, especially when everything is going very smoothly and the mind is calm, quiet, and peaceful. Don't deceive yourself by saying you have attained a jhāna! To gain concentration, you must train the mind with great diligence and mindfulness. Sleepiness is an impediment.

The fourth hindrance is restlessness and worry. We must overcome these to gain concentration.

The fifth is doubt about the Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha, your own practice, the instructions, or the instructor. Sangha here means the community of the Buddha's awakened disciples. Friends, the Buddha's teaching is pure and clear. It shows us how suffering arises and how we can become free from it. We should have confidence in this teaching and make the effort to put it into practice. As we observe our own minds, we see how greed and hatred disturb us and how letting go brings peace. Little by little, we understand the value of the teaching through our own experience. This understanding strengthens our confidence, removes our doubts and helps us continue when the practice is difficult.

These are *the five hindrances*. Three additional obstacles hinder our spiritual progress.

The next hindrance is ignorance. We do not see things as they really are. We have not understood the four noble truths: suffering, its cause, its cessation, and the path leading to its cessation. Nor do we understand dependent origination—how things arise through causes and conditions—or the noble eightfold path and how to practice it.

Because of ignorance, we expect things to remain as they are and give us lasting happiness. We hold on to the idea of a permanent self. We have not yet understood the three characteristics of existence: impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and nonself. Unsatisfactoriness means that what changes cannot give lasting satisfaction. Nonself, or selflessness, means that there is no permanent self. All these forms of not knowing fall under ignorance.

We may know these words very well. We may even explain them to others. But we have to look carefully at our own experience and see these truths for ourselves. This is how we develop wisdom.

The next obstacle is discontentment: nothing seems to please you. Even when you come to meditate, the practice has no appeal at that moment.

Finally, all other harmful, or unwholesome, mental states—jealousy, fear, anxiety, and tension—are obstacles. We must avoid them. Whenever they arise, we immediately return to mindfulness. From the very beginning, we must train the mind to be mindful in this way.

When a hindrance has already arisen, first know it clearly. Notice what it is and how it changes, without condemning yourself for its presence. Observing a hindrance does not mean encouraging it to remain.¹⁸

Suppose you sit down and remember someone who hurt you. You meant to pay attention to the breath, but now you are preparing an answer to that person. The conversation is not happening in front of you. Yet resentment is happening in your mind. You can recognize that difference. There is no need to finish every argument before returning to the practice.

If you become angry with yourself for being angry, you have added another difficulty. Remember the purpose of sitting: to train this very mind. A hindrance showing itself tells you where the work is needed. Acknowledge the resentment, stop supplying it with further arguments, and use the support appropriate to it. For anger, that support is mettā, loving-friendliness. We will discuss these supports next.

When the mind is ready to return to the breath, return. If the same resentment arises again, begin again. Repeated practice is part of the training; the return of a thought is not a reason to abandon the practice. For thoughts that persist, the section “When Thoughts Persist” explains further approaches. Here, remember the first step: know what is present so that you can respond wisely.

¹⁸ For observing a hindrance without self-condemnation, see Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 12, “Dealing with Distractions II,” opening discussion.

What Helps the Mind

There are eight aids or supports for gaining concentration. First, we must let go of greed.

The moment you think of clinging to anything—holding on to it tightly—you have an obstacle. The moment you let it go, you have support for your practice.

The next support is not getting upset or angry. Anger definitely disrupts the practice. To overcome it, we practice mettā, loving-friendliness for all living beings without any exception. Friends, this is a wonderful mental state to cultivate. It makes the mind calm, relaxed, and peaceful and helps us gain concentration.

Whenever you feel sleepy or drowsy, visualize a very bright light. This will help you to gain concentration.

For restlessness and worry, bring the mind to one simple, pure object, and focus on it with undivided attention. A scattered mind is like a heap of dust into which someone throws a rock. The stone scatters the dust everywhere. When you pour a little water onto the dust, it settles down and will not scatter.

Similarly, bring your attention to the breath to calm the mind, just as water settles the dust. The breath is a calm, peaceful object. Paying attention to it as it goes in and out is a very effective way to settle the mind.

To overcome doubt, examine dhamma analytically. Here, dhamma means a mind object. It is difficult to translate this into one word, but feeling gives us an example to examine. Feelings may be pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, with desire or without desire, and so forth. Analyze them. See how they arise. Feeling arises through contact: the meeting of a sense faculty, its object, and the consciousness that knows that object. There is contact through the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind. Even a thought or memory can be an object of contact and give rise to feeling.

Here, feeling means the pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral quality of an experience. A neutral feeling is neither pleasant nor unpleasant. When a feeling is pleasant, we may want it to continue. When it is unpleasant, we may resist it and seek something pleasant instead. When it is neutral, we may scarcely notice it and begin looking for something more interesting.

Suppose we eat a piece of ripe mango. The tongue, the taste, and the consciousness of that taste come together. With this contact, a pleasant feeling arises. We enjoy the sweetness. Then the thought may arise, “I want another piece.” Although we have eaten enough, we reach for more because we want to repeat the pleasure. The pleasant feeling and the desire for more are different experiences. Seeing this distinction helps us understand how feeling can give rise to craving.

With mindfulness, we can recognize both the pleasant feeling and the wanting that follows it. We can notice the urge for another piece without immediately acting on it. We observe how the taste fades, how the feeling changes, and how the wanting also changes. Feeling does not have to lead to craving. As we learn to understand it, we can experience pleasure without grasping at it and discomfort without adding resistance and agitation.

As we examine dhamma in this way, our doubt slowly fades away.

Wisdom, or knowledge, is the opposite of ignorance and another support for our practice. What is this knowledge? It is knowing the three stages of existing things: the moment of arising, the moment of reaching a peak, and the moment of passing away. Knowledge of arising and passing away becomes an aid or support for concentration.

Contentment also supports our practice. It means being satisfied with what we have, without continually wanting more. When spiritual joy arises, body and mind become

calm, relaxed, and peaceful, and that helps us gain concentration. Remember, this is not ordinary, worldly joy.

Finally, all wholesome, or beneficial, mental states help us to gain concentration. We must remember both the obstacles and these aids to practice.

You must have the patience to continue your practice without disturbance, especially when meditating on loving-friendliness. When you lack patience, you jump to wrong conclusions. Sometimes you feel you can develop mettā for certain people but not for others. With genuine mettā and deep patience, you can avoid that discrimination. Mettā practice also helps you tolerate any person's shortcomings.

If you read the mettā sutta, the discourse on practicing loving-friendliness, you can see that you need certain qualities to practice mettā. Without those qualities, the practice may not be effective or meaningful. You must be straightforward and gentle in your manner, neither proud nor arrogant. You must not be impudent or attached to certain families, and so forth. Patience is one of those requirements.¹⁹

At the beginning of your sitting, take a little time to practice loving-friendliness. Begin with yourself. Wish to live without hostility, to be safe, and to meet difficulties with understanding. Attend to what you mean by these wishes. Then extend the same goodwill to the people close to you, to people you scarcely know, to those with whom you have difficulties, and finally to all living beings.

You can use a few simple sentences silently. Let their meaning guide your attention. If you wish yourself peace while continuing to scold yourself for yesterday's mistake,

¹⁹ Sn 1.8, "Karaṇīyamettā Sutta," verses 143–44; also Khp 9.

notice that contradiction. You can acknowledge the mistake and wish to learn from it. You do not have to turn it into another reason for treating yourself harshly.

Bring to mind someone close to you. Perhaps a relative has been worried about a problem, and you have been worrying about it too. For this moment, put aside the conversation in which you explain what that person ought to do. Wish for the person to be free from hostility and able to face the difficulty wisely. You are practicing goodwill toward the person; you do not have to settle the problem during this sitting.

Next, include someone you do not know well. Perhaps you regularly see a person working in a shop but know nothing about that person's life. Usually you think only about what you want to buy. Now allow that person to be included in your goodwill. There is no need to imagine a story about the person's troubles. You can wish that person well without knowing those details.

Then consider someone toward whom you feel resentment. You may immediately remember the person's words or actions. Notice when you have left the practice and started repeating the argument. Return to the intention of loving-friendliness. You can recognize that an action was harmful and still wish for the person to become free from the hostility that causes harm. Do not add a condition that the person must first apologize or agree with you. Your practice is something you can undertake now.

Extend the wish to all living beings, including those you have never seen. You do not have to picture or name them all. Keep the meaning of the wish in mind, allowing it to include them without choosing who deserves it.

You may not feel equally friendly toward everyone at once. Recognize that honestly and continue cultivating goodwill without pretending to feel something you do not feel. Then put aside the words and give your attention to breathing in and breathing out.²⁰

As we turn from mettā to the breath, let loving-friendliness remain in the background as a basis of peace. Through mettā practice, the mind becomes free from anger, greed, and tension. We then attend to the breath with this peaceful mind.

The Direction of Our Thoughts

Before awakening, the Buddha examined the thoughts arising in his own mind. He separated them into two groups. One contained sensual desire, hostility, and cruelty. The other contained renunciation, or letting go, goodwill, and the intention not to harm. He paid attention to where a thought would lead.²¹

When a thought of sensual desire arose, he recognized it. He considered the distress it could bring to himself, to others, or to both. He also considered how such thinking interfered with wisdom and led away from freedom. As he understood these consequences, the thought subsided. He examined hostility and cruelty in the same way. Recognizing a thought and its effects helped him abandon it.

We do not have to wait until a hostile intention has become speech or action before seeing where it leads. As soon as it arises, we can consider the suffering it could bring to ourselves and other people.

The kinds of thought we repeatedly entertain become the mind's inclination. When we keep returning to desire, the mind leans toward desire. When we keep returning to

²⁰ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 9, "Set Up Exercises," "Universal Loving-Kindness."

²¹ MN 19, §§2–5.

hostility, the mind leans toward hostility. The same principle applies to thoughts of letting go, goodwill, and harmlessness. What we return to gains strength.

To illustrate the first part of his training, the Buddha describes a cowherd watching cattle while the crops are still standing. The animals cannot simply be left to roam wherever they wish. The cowherd keeps them back, moving from one side to the other with his stick. If they enter the growing crops, he may face punishment, confinement, financial loss, or blame. He understands the consequences of carelessness and guards the herd accordingly.

In the same way, the Buddha saw the trouble in unwholesome states and the benefit of relinquishing them. Knowing the danger, he guarded his mind.²²

What happens when the thought is wholesome? Thoughts of renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness did not carry the same danger. They did not lead to affliction for him or for others. They supported wisdom and freedom. He could see no harm in continuing with them, even for a whole day and night.

Yet he noticed something more. Thinking could continue beyond what was useful. Prolonged reflection could tire the body, and bodily tiredness could disturb the mind. A mind disturbed in this way was not ready for concentration. So he allowed the mind to settle inwardly and become unified. Wholesome thinking had served a purpose; he did not need to keep producing it without end.²³

The second cowherd image shows this change. The harvest has been gathered into the villages. The cowherd can now sit beneath a tree or remain in the open, remembering

²² MN 19, §7.

²³ MN 19, §§8–10.

where the cattle are. He still knows the herd is there, but the circumstances no longer call for the earlier constant checking. The Buddha compares this to knowing that the wholesome states are present. Mindfulness continues while the activity of guarding becomes less demanding.²⁴

Awareness remains, but there is less to struggle with. The Buddha continued with energy and mindfulness, his body calm and his mind collected. From there, he entered the jhānas and attained awakening.²⁵

The Buddha gives another image. A herd of deer lives near a low-lying pool in a forest. Someone intending their harm blocks the safe route, opens a dangerous route, and sets out a lure and a decoy. Another person, wishing for the herd's welfare, reverses this arrangement: the safe way is opened, the dangerous way is closed, and the deceptive devices are removed.

The dangerous route is the wrong path; the safe route is the noble eightfold path. Craving, a thirst or longing, is the lure, and ignorance is the decoy. The Buddha has opened the safe way and removed these dangers. Now the monks must practice. He directs them to the roots of trees and empty dwellings, urging them to meditate without delay.²⁶

Finding the Right Effort

Faith is confidence in the Buddha's awakening and the path he taught. Energy is the effort to abandon unwholesome states and develop wholesome ones. Mindfulness keeps

²⁴ MN 19, §12.

²⁵ MN 19, §§13–24.

²⁶ MN 19, §§25–27.

us aware of what is happening and helps us remember the purpose of our practice.

Concentration gathers the mind and keeps it steady with its object. Wisdom understands the changing nature of experience and sees how attachment leads to suffering. These are the five faculties, or mental capacities, and we must maintain a balance among them.

When one faculty is stronger than the others, we must learn to bring it into balance.

When we need to exert the mind—that is, when we are lazy—we should arouse energy and make an effort to continue the practice. Laziness is very common. People quickly slouch, become lethargic and sleepy, and fall asleep. It is so easy to do! We must learn to put forth energy to overcome sleepiness.

We also restrain the mind when it needs restraint. Sleepiness is one extreme; a wandering mind is the other. When the mind moves from sleepiness to wandering, we must overcome that wandering as well.

Then we look at the mind with equanimity when that is what it needs. When the mind leans to one side or another, it becomes biased by various emotions: greed, anger, jealousy, fear, and so forth. When these emotions arise, we must learn to restore the mind's balance so that we can continue the practice.

Make an effort without struggling too much, because excessive struggle makes you unnecessarily tired. You can see this when walking or climbing. Children run very fast at the beginning, then get tired toward the end and cannot finish. Similarly, too much effort at the beginning leaves us unable to go far. We lose interest and cannot continue.

Therefore, right effort means balancing your effort. To do this, focus your mind on the tranquilizing factors of enlightenment: tranquility, concentration, and equanimity.

Your effort will not be excessive, and your mind will become calmer. You do not give up; you sustain the effort needed to continue practicing.

To continue our practice, we need wisdom, patience, and understanding. These qualities help us balance our effort: too much makes us tired very quickly; too little makes us sleepy. We also need determination. Remember tranquility, concentration, and equanimity, and bring your mind to those states to maintain this balance.

Soṇa and the Lute

Soṇa had put considerable energy into the training, yet he had not reached the freedom he sought. While living alone in the Cool Grove near Rājagaha, he began considering another course. His family had wealth. Perhaps he could give up the monastic training, return to household life, enjoy those resources, and continue doing good.²⁷

The Buddha became aware of his thoughts and came to him. Rather than ask Soṇa simply to exert himself more, he turned to something Soṇa already understood. Before becoming a monk, Soṇa had been skilled at playing a lute. The Buddha asked him about its strings.

Strings stretched too tightly would not make for a well-tuned, playable instrument. Strings left slack would not do so either. Soṇa knew both problems. When the tension was properly adjusted, the instrument could be played well.

The Buddha applied this to energy in meditation. Excessive exertion encourages agitation; inadequate exertion encourages idleness. Soṇa was to bring his energy into balance, attend to the balance of the faculties, and take up the meditation object on that basis. He could continue the training with a different understanding of effort.

²⁷ AN 6.55.

Soṇa followed the instruction. He adjusted his energy and faculties, continued in seclusion, and practiced diligently. In time, he realized arahantship, or full enlightenment.

When Soṇa later spoke with the Buddha, he described what a liberated mind inclines toward: relinquishment, seclusion, non-harming, the ending of craving, the ending of clinging, and freedom from confusion.

These qualities need to be understood carefully. Seclusion in one who has completed the path is not a way of seeking recognition. Renunciation is not merely an expression of belief. Harmlessness does not come from treating rules and observances as sufficient by themselves. These qualities arise because greed, hatred, and delusion have ended.

He then spoke of strong sensory impressions. Forms, sounds, smells, tastes, touches, and mental objects can still be encountered, yet they do not overwhelm the liberated mind. Their passing can be known without the mind being swept away. Soṇa compared this stability to a solid mountain that remains unmoved when violent wind and rain arrive from any direction.

This is the freedom toward which Soṇa's effort was directed. He had needed to adjust his practice, then continue with it. The balanced effort of training had led to a mind that remained steady amid changing experience.²⁸

When We Resist Practicing

Resistance to practice comes from hindrances. To overcome greed, the first hindrance, think about the impermanence of the object you are attached to, whether it is a sight, sound, smell, taste, or touch. If you long for a particular sight, remember that both the object you see and your memory of it are impermanent.

²⁸ AN 6.55.

When you see an object, something else may enter your mind the next moment. You forget the first object, and then the next, and the next. The objects themselves also change. Changes in outside objects are not easy to notice, but you can see changes in your own experience, in your own mind. See that the object you saw is impermanent.

Sound is an even better example. It comes in waves that are constantly changing. Smells reach the nose through the air and change quickly too. When something passes beyond the taste buds, you no longer taste it. In this way, we can experience impermanence. Touch also reveals impermanence. To get rid of desire, the first hindrance, you must see impermanence very clearly.

To overcome hatred, practice mettā, or loving-friendliness. Cultivate the sincere wish that we and all beings, without any exception, be happy and peaceful.

Think of the dangers of anger. You become very unhappy and unpleasant, and it shows on your face. You cannot look at people with clear, friendly eyes. Every time you see something you don't like, a very bad mental state arises, and you must experience it. Remember, "In the past, I had this pain when I experienced this unpleasant thing. Even now it is happening; in the future it will happen. So I must let it go. Practice mettā."

Mindfulness is not limited to sitting meditation. While engaging in conversation with somebody, pay attention to your mind. This is called daily mindfulness practice. During a conversation or discussion, your ego suddenly comes to the fore. Immediately become aware: "This is impermanent. There is no such thing as a permanent self. If I promote my ideas, what do I gain? I don't gain one iota of peace or happiness. I boost my ego. The more I boost my ego, the more painful it is for me, because everybody else is not going to respect my ego. Therefore, it is I who suffer, not them."

Even while engaged in conversation, we can make an effort to remove the hindrances. When you speak with greed, people can recognize it. They think, “This is a greedy person.” They do not want to associate with someone who is always trying to get more and will not let anything go. It is the same with hatred. People do not want to be close to someone who speaks with hatred. When we understand this, we should make every effort to remove greed and hatred from the mind.

You can use the same techniques to overcome any hindrance both while sitting in meditation and in daily life.

When your work requires thinking, give attention to the work. Suppose you are using a computer to solve a problem. You must remember what you have tried, compare possibilities, and decide what to do next. A thought may lead to several further thoughts because the task requires them. You do not have to stop that process simply because you are practicing mindfulness. Learn to recognize what the mind is doing as you work.

Perhaps the result is wrong and you have to examine the problem again. At first, your thinking concerns the steps you have taken. Then impatience enters: “I should have finished this already.” You begin imagining how badly others will judge you. Soon you are arguing with an imagined critic while the problem remains untouched. The mind has moved from examining the work to becoming caught in a reaction to it.

When you notice this, recognize the impatience and return to what needs attention. You may have to check the same step several times. That repetition can be necessary. The question is whether you are examining something that needs examination or repeatedly feeding the same complaint. We learn this by looking at what is happening, not by deciding in advance that every repeated thought is a distraction.

An interruption offers another opportunity. Someone asks a question while you are working, and irritation arises. Notice the impulse to answer sharply. You still have to decide what to do: answer the question now, explain that you need a little time, or return to the task. Mindfulness helps you recognize the state of mind from which you are about to speak. There is no need to let irritation make the decision for you.

This does not require you to comment inwardly on everything you think. You are learning to recognize when greed, hatred, or delusion begins to influence the work. Perhaps you dismiss a useful suggestion because you want all the credit. Perhaps you refuse to examine an error because you do not want to admit it. These are matters for mindfulness, even while the subject of your thinking is an ordinary practical task.

When you stop working, notice whether your thoughts remain occupied with the work. You may need to remember an unfinished question or decide when to return to it. But you may also find yourself rehearsing the same grievance after you have left the computer. Recognize what you are continuing to carry. Is there something to be done now, or are you going over the irritation again?

During a period set aside for meditation, put the work aside and return to the breath. During work, attend to the task and be willing to recognize your reactions. The circumstances differ, but in both you can learn when the mind is becoming caught and bring attention back to what you are doing.²⁹

Sometimes we find meditation boring and monotonous even when we have plenty of time for it. In that case, we need to consider the meditation object we are using. The

²⁹ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 15, “Meditation in Everyday Life,” opening discussion and the paragraphs on responding to practical situations and observing everyday reactions.

breath, for instance, will not tire or bore us when we attend to it. It opens up more and more areas of the mind, allowing us to see reality more clearly.

You become aware, for example, of various negative mental states disappearing from your mind. As they disappear, wholesome mental states arise. One is faith, which arises from knowing, seeing, and understanding things. That is called faith endowed with knowledge: faith that comes from realizing the truth.

When faith endowed with knowledge arises, joy arises with it. This is faith in the Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha, and impermanence, and in dependent origination—the teaching of how suffering arises through conditions and ceases when those conditions cease. Through understanding these realities, we must develop deep faith in them. Joy arises from understanding suffering. Suffering is real, and when we see it as it really is, we are delighted to see the truth. This is a way of overcoming boredom and monotony and continuing with real peace deeply rooted in the mind.

There is no harm in feeling grateful to the Buddha and to those who give us correct advice and instruction. That gratitude helps fill us with joy and pleasure.

Knowing the truth gives us confidence in the Buddha's enlightenment. His infallible instructions on meditation strengthen this trust. Developing such confidence is an achievement, a step forward in the practice.

Knowing What We Are Doing

Sati is the Pali word translated into English as “mindfulness.” Pali is the language in which these teachings were preserved. These three go together: sati, mindfulness; sampajañña, clear comprehension; and yoniso manasikāra, attention to the roots of our mental states.

Yoniso manasikāra means that when a certain mental state arises—for instance, greed—we must understand the root from which it arises. Yoni means origin. Because greed is present in me, a greedy thought arises in me. Hatred is another root. Because that root is in me, a hateful thought arises. There is also confusion in me.

Confusion in the Buddhist technical sense generally means not seeing the truth as it is. You don't see the four noble truths very clearly. A confused state arises in me because of the root of confusion. Seeing things from the root is yoniso manasikāra.

We can use yoniso manasikāra to develop clear comprehension, sampajañña. Clear comprehension has four parts. One is the purpose, mentioned at the very beginning of the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, the discourse on the foundations of mindfulness. The second is the means of attaining that purpose. The third is the field of this practice, and the fourth is nonconfusion.

We must clearly comprehend the purpose of practice. The subject we choose should be suitable for attaining that goal. Gocara is the domain: the four foundations of mindfulness. Asamoha means nonconfusion with regard to all this. These are the steps to clear comprehension.

Let us apply these four parts to the conversation mentioned earlier. Somebody questions your opinion, and immediately you want to defend yourself. Before replying, remember the purpose of the practice. Are you trying to increase irritation, or to understand and lessen it? The purpose is still the purification of the mind and freedom from suffering. It has not changed simply because you have left the meditation seat.

Next consider suitability. A sharp reply may give you a moment of satisfaction, but will it help fulfill that purpose? Perhaps a short pause will allow you to hear what the

other person actually said. Perhaps you can answer plainly and gently. We choose an action by considering whether it supports the training, not merely whether it expresses the feeling of the moment.

Then remember the domain. The body may be tense, the feeling unpleasant, and the mind angry. These are things you can know through the foundations of mindfulness. You do not have to leave the conversation and search for a different life in which to practice. The experience taking place here gives you something to understand.

Finally, remain unconfused about what you are doing. Recognize the difference between understanding the situation and defending the idea that you are always right. You may still explain your view, but the explanation need not be driven by resentment. Purpose, suitability, domain, and nonconfusion guide the same response. At first we may reflect on them deliberately. With practice, this understanding can inform how we listen and speak without turning every conversation into a long internal discussion.³⁰

Yoniso manasikāra and clear comprehension together are what we call sati, mindfulness. Although we use the word “mindfulness” loosely, real mindfulness has all these components. By combining them, we develop our awareness. This is the simplest definition I can give of mindfulness.

³⁰ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, Wisdom Academy course, lesson 6, “Differentiating Mindfulness from Meditation,” transcript, 1–2.

Chapter 3

Knowing the Breath



Our mind is like a wild calf that has drunk a lot of its mother's milk and runs and jumps about without direction or control.

To tame this animal, a person ties a rope to it and secures the other end to a post firmly sunk into the ground. The animal tries to run but cannot go beyond the length of the rope. It circles the post until it finally settles down.

Similarly, the nostrils are the post. Some people have difficulty feeling the breath there. They need to pay close attention to find the point where it makes contact, and that takes some effort. It may be at the nostrils, the tip of the nose, or the upper lip, depending on the shape of the nose. Some people's noses turn up; they may feel the breath touching

their upper lip. Each person must find this point of contact, the firm post to which the mind is tethered. With mindfulness, we train the mind to stay in one place.³¹

First, you must recognize the nature of your mind. Then resolve to train it so that it no longer behaves like a wild animal. With that determination, focus on the breath with undivided attention. Gradually, the mind learns to stay there.

Notice the breath, then the point where it touches your nose. We cannot notice the breath without this contact. Feeling arises from contact. As you feel the breath, the wandering mind, like a wild animal, gradually comes to rest on it.

Notice the touch of the breath. Notice the feeling of the breath. Notice the perception of the breath. Notice attention itself. Once the mind begins to notice all these, wandering stops. Gently and diligently, we train the mind to stay with the breath. The training is systematic and gradual.

Think about a man watching a baby in a swing. The man sits nearby in a chair. He is disabled and cannot move his head. When the swing comes in front of his nose, he notices it and taps it to the left. On its return, he taps it to the right. He cannot follow its movement to either end; he sees it only as it passes in front of him.

The mindful meditator keeps the mind in the present moment. As the breath moves in and out, we notice its touch at the nostrils. The touch is constantly changing, but it occurs so quickly that it seems permanent. To understand this, we must focus very sharply on the touch of the breath.

Another simile is that of a gatekeeper. The gatekeeper does not concern himself with the details of the people going in and coming out. He simply notices them as they pass

³¹ Compare Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, VIII.153–154.

through the gate. He is not concerned about someone who has already gone inside or someone who has left.

Paying attention to the breath can sometimes be very tricky. As we consider all these details, you might wonder, “How can we keep the mind focused only on the touch of the breath at the tip of the nose or the nostrils?”

We can understand this with an example of a saw. There is a big log on level ground. You take a saw to cut it. You are aware that the saw has many teeth, but you focus only on the point where they touch the log.

You don’t watch all the teeth of the saw going back and forth. You stay aware of where you are cutting the wood so that you cut in the right place, without zigzagging here and there. Similarly, when you focus on the breath, you must keep the mind in one place. The mind is always unsteady, so keeping it focused there is not easy.³²

If the mind keeps wandering, counting can help it stay with breathing. As you breathe in and out, count silently from one to ten and then back to one, keeping the numbers connected to the breath. When you lose your place, begin again at one.

Remember what the counting is helping you to do. Each number accompanies an experience of breathing. The important thing is to know that experience. You can remember a series of numbers very well and still pay little attention to the breath. Reaching the end of the count does not by itself tell you how clearly you have been observing.

Suppose you reach ten and find that you have also been planning tomorrow’s work. The counting continued, but the breath received very little attention. When you recognize

³² Compare Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, VIII.199–203.

this, return to the feeling of breathing. Do not become occupied with whether you performed the counting correctly. Use it to bring the mind back to the subject for which you began counting.

As attention becomes steady on the breath, leave the numbers aside. What remains? The breath is still coming in and going out, and you are aware of it. Nothing needs to be said about each breath. This is nonverbal awareness: knowing the experience without describing it to yourself. You know that you are sitting without having to repeat the word “sitting” continually. In the same way, you can know breathing without continually naming or numbering it.

There is no need to replace the numbers with comments such as “That was a good breath” or “Now I am doing better.” Those comments can become another occupation. Stay with the breath you feel. If you have stopped counting but are still silently rehearsing the next number, recognize that habit and let it go. Keep your attention on breathing.

The change from counting to direct awareness does not require a special experience or a fixed number of successful rounds. Notice whether the aid is still needed. When it has gathered the mind around the breath, you can continue without it. If you discover that attention has wandered, recognize that and return. The purpose throughout is to know breathing, with the numbers serving that purpose while they are useful.³³

³³ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 5, “The Practice,” “Counting,” and the preceding discussion of nonverbal awareness.

When Thoughts Persist

A distracting thought sometimes disappears as soon as it is recognized. At other times, a thought connected with wanting, hostility, or confusion continues to return. In the Vitakkasaṇṭhāna Sutta, the Buddha gives five ways of working with such thoughts. When one approach has not brought them to an end, another is available.³⁴

The first response is to turn your attention to something else. If attention to one object or feature brings up unwholesome thinking, direct it instead toward something associated with the wholesome. The Buddha compares this to a carpenter or an apprentice using a smaller peg to dislodge a larger one. As attention rests on the wholesome object, the obstructing thoughts subside and the mind can collect itself.³⁵

If those thoughts continue, the second response is to examine their danger. Consider their unwholesome nature, their blameworthiness, and the suffering to which they lead. Instead of being absorbed in what the thought promises or argues, notice what will happen if you keep thinking it.

The Buddha gives a deliberately unpleasant image. A young person who cares about their appearance finds a dead snake, dog, or human body placed around their neck. Instead of enjoying the adornment, the person recoils from it. Harmful thinking can be understood as such a burden, something not worth carrying. With its abandonment, the mind is again able to settle.³⁶

The third response is to stop giving the thought attention. A person with good eyesight who does not wish to look at something can close the eyes or look elsewhere.

³⁴ MN 20, §§2–8.

³⁵ MN 20, §3.

³⁶ MN 20, §4.

Similarly, we can withdraw the attention that keeps returning to an unwholesome thought. We have already considered its danger; we need not keep examining it.³⁷

When that does not suffice, the fourth response is to quiet the activity that forms the thoughts. The Buddha explains this through a sequence of bodily movements. A person walking quickly considers why such speed is necessary and slows down. Then the person questions whether even this movement is necessary and stands still. Standing gives way to sitting and sitting to lying down. At each change, a more active posture is replaced by one requiring less activity.

The movement becomes gentler, then stops. In the same way, we attend to quieting the process of thought formation rather than keeping it going. The changing postures illustrate this settling of mental activity.³⁸

The fifth response is forceful. If unwholesome thoughts still persist, the Buddha describes pressing the teeth together and the tongue against the palate, then using the mind to subdue and restrain the mind. He compares this to a stronger person holding down someone weaker. This strong restraint comes after the gentler approaches have failed. It is directed at thoughts bound up with desire, hostility, and confusion. We need not treat every harmless thought as something to be attacked.³⁹

When the obstructing thoughts are abandoned, the mind can remain collected. The Buddha describes the accomplished practitioner as able to think when thinking is wanted and to leave thought aside when it is not wanted. Such a practitioner has ended craving,

³⁷ MN 20, §5.

³⁸ MN 20, §6.

³⁹ MN 20, §7.

broken the mental bonds called fetters, and brought suffering to an end. The mind remains capable of thought, free from being driven by it.⁴⁰

Long and Short Breathing

In the following instructions, the whole body of breath means the breath in its entirety, with its beginning, middle, and end. The bodily formations are inhaling and exhaling, which condition the body.

“Breathing in long, he understands, ‘I breathe in long.’ Or breathing out long, he understands, ‘I breathe out long.’ Breathing in short, he understands, ‘I breathe in short.’ Or breathing out short, he understands, ‘I breathe out short.’

“He trains thus: ‘I shall breathe in experiencing the whole body of breath.’ He trains thus: ‘I shall breathe out experiencing the whole body of breath.’

“He trains thus: ‘I shall breathe in tranquilizing the bodily formations.’ He trains thus: ‘I shall breathe out tranquilizing the bodily formations.’”⁴¹

These four pairs make up the first tetrad of exercises.

The words “I breathe in long” are used for teaching. We do not recite them as we breathe. What should we do? Understand that this is a long breath.

When the incoming breath is long, we simply become aware of its length. Even here, we don’t say “my breath.” Words serve only to explain the experience to somebody else. Know and experience the long exhalation in the same way.

⁴⁰ MN 20, §8.

⁴¹ Adapted from MN 118, §18.

We know the long inhalation and exhalation without putting them into words. I emphasize this because our aim is eventually to stop verbalizing: words stimulate the mind to build more concepts and ideas. Simply experience the breath as it comes and goes naturally.

After a while, our breath becomes short. We are not talking about being short of breath. Inhaling and exhaling naturally return to their normal length and rhythm. Occasionally, when the lungs are tired, we take a long inhalation and a long exhalation. That, too, happens naturally. Our training is to calm the body. We work on this from the very beginning.

Breathing in short, we understand, “I breathe in short.” Just as with a long breath, we must experience the short inhalation as we breathe in and the short exhalation as we breathe out.

The Whole Breath Body

After learning to recognize long and short breaths, we come to the third instruction: “He trains thus: ‘I shall breathe in experiencing the whole body of breath.’” The Buddha described inhaling and exhaling as a body among bodies.⁴²

Let me explain why the entire breath is taken as a body, the breath body.

How does breath become a body? It has a beginning, middle, and end. It is a body of air, the element of movement. The complete air element is taken as the body. This is how the commentaries and subcommentaries explain it. Therefore, without any hesitation, we must regard the breath as one whole body, the breath body.

⁴² MN 118, §24.

What do we need to make a body? We need the four elements: earth, water, fire, and air. These describe physical qualities: earth is solidity, water is cohesion, fire is temperature, and air is movement. In the breath, you can find all of them. You feel the breath touching the nostrils, the upper lip, or the inside of the nose. That touch is due to the presence of the earth element.

The breath also has moisture. We notice this when the humidity is high. When the air outside is dry, we feel that dryness as we breathe in.

When we breathe in and out, we feel the heat in the air. That is the fire, or heat, element. Then we feel movement, or oscillation, which is the function of the air element. For all practical purposes, all four elements are present in the breath, although they are very subtle. Therefore, it is called the breath body.

We begin by focusing on the breath at the nostrils. As the practice develops, we learn to experience the whole breath body, noticing its beginning at the nose, its middle in the chest, and its end in the lower abdomen. The initial focus at the nostrils provides the foundation for this fuller awareness.

When you breathe out, the lower abdomen is the beginning, the chest is the middle, and the nostrils, tip of the nose, or upper lip are the end. As your awareness develops, you become aware of these subtle points of touch.

The saw and gatekeeper similes help us establish steadiness at the beginning. We learn to remain with what is happening instead of running after every thought. As this steadiness develops, awareness can include more of the breathing experience. The breath remains the subject throughout. We have not left it to think about something else.

For example, the contact at the nose may be clear while movement in the chest is less distinct. Attend to what you can actually feel. As the chest and abdomen become clearer, include them in your awareness of the whole breath. We are learning to know this bodily experience, without making a picture of an invisible stream of air or trying to manufacture sensations at each point.

The beginning, middle, and end also remind us to stay with the breath as it unfolds. Do not hurry toward the end of an inhalation while its beginning is still being felt. If the mind wanders into imagining or planning, return to the familiar contact at the nostrils and renew the steadiness from which fuller awareness develops.

With effort, we learn to keep our attention on the breath and maintain mindfulness throughout. Each of the sixteen instructions includes an inhalation and an exhalation, giving us thirty-two kinds of mindful experience. We come to know them only by paying mindful attention to every stage of breathing.

When you give a long breath your full attention, the mind is undisturbed and mindfulness is established. You are fully aware of the inhalation as you breathe in and of the exhalation as you breathe out. That awareness becomes knowledge. With mindfulness and knowledge, you continue to pay attention.

The sixteen instructions form four groups of four, called tetrads. Each group has eight individual stages: an inhalation and an exhalation for each instruction. Let us take the first group. You know the long inhalation as you breathe in and the long exhalation as you breathe out. These form one pair. Knowing the short inhalation and exhalation forms another. Together, they make four individual stages.

Then you train yourself to experience the whole breath body as you breathe in and out. This third pair brings the total to six individual practices. The next two practices are tranquilizing the inhalation and tranquilizing the exhalation. There are eight individual stages of breathing in this first section. Similarly, the second, third, and fourth sections each have eight stages. Altogether, there are thirty-two individual stages. These are called the thirty-two kinds of knowledge of inhaling and exhaling.⁴³

Sometimes the out-breath is clearer; sometimes the in-breath is clearer. Pay attention to both inhaling and exhaling so that your awareness of the entire breathing process is complete. Eventually, there is a moment when inhaling and exhaling connect, and you cannot distinguish between them at that point. Keep the mind balanced while remaining aware of inhaling and exhaling.

This subject is profound and not easy to understand. As we continue practicing, we bring the practice to perfection, and all these distractions disappear. Of course, this does not happen quickly. If it does, you can be sure that you are asleep!

Tranquilizing the Body

Inhaling and exhaling condition this body. When we breathe in, we bring oxygen into our lungs and recharge the oxygen-depleted red blood cells. Without oxygen, the cells don't last. The oxygen-rich blood goes to the heart, which pumps it all over the body. Oxygen-depleted blood then returns to the heart and is sent to the lungs to be recharged with oxygen.

⁴³ *Paṭisambhidāmagga*, Treatise III, §183, in Ñāṇamoli, *The Path of Discrimination*, 214–15; see also Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, VIII.163.

Therefore, the Buddha called inhaling and exhaling a body conditioner. We have skin conditioners, hair conditioners, and nail conditioners, but the body conditioner is the most important of all.

Inhaling and exhaling are the bodily formations. They are conditions, or conditioners, of the body. When the breath itself becomes tranquil, calm, relaxed, and peaceful, that is called tranquilizing the bodily formations.⁴⁴

Tranquilizing ourselves through mindfulness of breathing is the most effective way to live a very peaceful life. We begin by training the body through breathing, which in turn trains the mind. Then the mind trains the body to remain calm and peaceful.

Even enlightened persons sometimes have physical ailments, but their minds are not sick. They have gotten rid of all their defilements—the unwholesome states, such as greed, hatred, and delusion, that disturb the mind—and remain very peaceful all the time.

Remain awake, remain mindful. Give the breath your full attention so that you can know its beginning, middle, and end, and develop the thirty-two kinds of knowledge of breathing. As you continue, the gross, or coarse, inhalations and exhalations become increasingly subtle, until the breath is tranquil—calm, relaxed, and peaceful.

We can experience this when we ring a gong or a big bell. At first, the sound is strong and coarse. Listen mindfully, without interruption. If you wait with full awareness, you can hear it gradually fade until it disappears.

Similarly, as we attend to the breath, it becomes progressively subtler, and we gain tranquility. Until then, remain fully aware and mindful. Don't let the mind become caught in any of those obstacles. Stay with the breath.

⁴⁴ MN 44, §§13–15.

As mindfulness builds up in meditation, all obstacles fade away, all wholesome mental states arise, and you gain concentration. This concentration arises from mindfulness of breathing. Therefore, this is a subject for both tranquility meditation and insight meditation.⁴⁵

This is a certain body among bodies, namely in-breathing and out-breathing. On that occasion, one abides contemplating the body as a body, ardent, fully aware, and mindful, having put away covetousness and grief for the world. Ardent means having the determination to overcome defilements. We are fully aware and mindful, having put away covetousness—greed for others' property—and grief in the world. The world means this body and mind. Mindfulness and awareness arise in this mind and body.⁴⁶

When the Breath Becomes Very Subtle

The traditional instructions offer a practical reminder for when you cannot feel the breath. The breath has not gone simply because you no longer notice it. Your consciousness has not disappeared. When you are unconscious or in the fourth jhāna, you do not feel it, but merely sitting down to meditate does not mean you have attained the fourth jhāna. Remember that the breath is still there.⁴⁷

In the *Visuddhimagga*, or *The Path of Purification*, we find a simile that illustrates this point beautifully. After plowing his field, the farmer unhitches his buffaloes in the middle of the day and rests under a tree, knowing they are there. The buffaloes roam into the forest and keep grazing, sometimes for several hours. The farmer does not worry,

⁴⁵ Compare Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, VIII.207.

⁴⁶ MN 118, §24.

⁴⁷ For this traditional guidance when the breath becomes imperceptible, see Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, VIII.208–211.

knowing they will go where there is water. Taking his rope, he goes to wait for them by the pond, tank, river, or other watering place they visit.

When the buffaloes come to drink and rest in the water, he very gently ties them up again and leads them back to plow.⁴⁸

Similarly, the breath is still there. To notice it, take several quick breaths. You will feel it again at its familiar point of contact.

However, when you no longer feel the breath but notice vibration, don't worry about the breath. Focus your mind on the vibration. It is happening all the time in our mind and body because, as we breathe in and out, all the tiny particles in the body are changing. Outside meditation, we don't notice these changes, but they continue.

When we are in meditation, the mind becomes calm, relaxed, and peaceful. There are no hindrances, no disturbances. You can then notice even the tiniest thing: the faintest sound, a very subtle smell or touch, or any vibration. Vibration is an indication of impermanence.

We must focus the mind on impermanence. We can understand it intellectually, but now we begin to feel vibration. This is when we really experience impermanence.

You have two choices. To return to the breath, follow the suggestion I made earlier. If you are not worried about the breath and the vibration is strong, stay with the vibration. Then you notice sensations rising and falling, appearing and disappearing with the vibration.

⁴⁸ Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, VIII.208–213.

To notice rising and falling is to notice impermanence. In vibration, you can see very subtle changes of this kind. This makes vibration a very good object of attention for understanding the nature of impermanence.

The Sign of Concentration

The word *nimitta* means sign. We must be clear and skillful in noticing the sign. There are all kinds of confused beliefs about signs, and we must not be misled by them.

The *term* is used in concentration and also in *vipassanā*, or insight meditation. In *vipassanā*, we speak of the signs of greed, hatred, and delusion.

During concentration practice, the mind becomes increasingly sharp and unified. Here I am using the breath as the object of meditation. A very fine sensation arises at the place where the breath touches. The mind is clean and pure, and everything is calm. At that moment, the sign of concentration arises.

What is the sign of concentration? It is like a little tuft of cotton rubbing against your nostrils, or a very fine bird's feather brushing the tip of your nose, or a little flame—not a burning flame, but a soft, flame-like object touching your nostrils or nose. It may even be like a flower petal gently touching your nose, or waves of air touching your nose.

The sign becomes clear and prominent. You see a sparkle, a bright light, and the next moment you gain concentration.

These descriptions concern a mind becoming clear and collected. The form of the sign may differ from one meditator to another. The descriptions are examples to help us recognize the experience; they are not instructions to produce a feather, a flame, or a light. Continue the training that makes the mind steady instead of waiting impatiently for a particular appearance.

We must also be clear about what concentration means here. Early efforts establish preliminary concentration. In access concentration, the stage approaching absorption, the qualities of concentration are present but still developing. In absorption concentration, or jhāna, these qualities hold the mind fully on its object. These distinctions help us understand the approach to jhāna without treating every moment of calm as the completed attainment.⁴⁹

Suppose a bright appearance is followed by excitement about what it means. Notice the excitement. If you begin planning how to describe the experience to somebody, the mind is now occupied with that plan. Return to the practice. A description of a sign cannot do the work of attending carefully to the actual state of mind. The next chapter explains the first jhāna through the hindrances that are absent and the qualities that are present together.

In vipassanā, signs of greed include clinging, craving, and so forth. Hatred means anger, and delusion means confusion. These are different from the signs in concentration meditation.

Sometimes a bright light appears during concentration, and you may wonder how to move from that experience to insight. The light itself is not permanent. Stay with it calmly, without wandering thoughts or agitation, and you will see it gradually fade away. When it disappears, recognize, “Even this light is impermanent.” At that moment, the

⁴⁹ For differences in the sign among meditators, see Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 5, “The Practice,” discussion following the farmer’s simile. For preliminary, access, and absorption concentration, see Gunaratana, *The Jhanas in Theravada Buddhist Meditation*, chap. 1, “Jhana and Samadhi,” and chap. 3, “The Factors of the First Jhana.”

mind naturally turns from concentration toward insight. Whatever the mind creates is impermanent. Seeing this in your own experience is the beginning of vipassanā.

Giving the Practice Time

Patience allows the practice to develop without a demand for new experiences. The breath already offers changing sensations to observe. Deliberately making it long or short can disturb its ordinary rhythm; mindfulness learns that rhythm and the changes occurring within it. If agitation is present, it too can be recognized without turning the sitting into a struggle to manufacture calm.

We can understand patience through the example of two hens. One repeatedly disturbs her eggs in her hurry to see chicks. The other gives the eggs the sustained care needed for hatching. This comparison helps us turn our attention from wanting an immediate result to maintaining the conditions for development.

Recognizing that the mind has wandered is itself a useful moment of awareness. We can renew attention without adding anger at ourselves. When we patiently repeat this recognition and return, the practice can deepen.⁵⁰

⁵⁰ For the two-hens comparison and patiently returning after distraction, see Gunaratana, *The Four Foundations of Mindfulness in Plain English*, chap. 1, 25–27.

Chapter 4

Joy and Happiness



Experiencing Rapture and Pleasure

The breath becomes tranquil gradually. At first it is gross; then it becomes subtler. You become aware of the entire breath body. After that, the breath becomes extremely subtle—very calm, relaxed, and peaceful. That is called tranquility.

Once tranquility is established and you have overcome the obstructions, you reach a stage where very subtle meditative feeling arises. In the instructions that follow, rapture means joy, and the term mental formations refers here to feeling and perception.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing rapture.” He trains thus: “I shall breathe out experiencing rapture.”

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing pleasure.” He trains thus: “I shall breathe out experiencing pleasure.”

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing mental formations.” He

trains thus: “I shall breathe out experiencing the mental formations.”

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in tranquilizing the mental formations.” He

trains thus: “I shall breathe out tranquilizing the mental formations.”⁵¹

What is this rapture, called *pīti*? It arises when the breath is calm, subtle, and peaceful. That is the stage at which you attain the first *jhāna*. You don’t put it into words. You simply become aware of it. You breathe in while experiencing that rapture, and you breathe out with the same awareness.

As you breathe in, experience the rapture without interrupting it. You don’t put it into words, saying, “This is rapture. I shall train myself to experience rapture,” and so forth. Words disturb it.

That is why the instruction says, “He trains.” This does not happen automatically; it takes repeated practice because the mind is like a wild animal. It wanders here and there, going to the past or the future through sight, sound, smell, taste, touch, and thought—through the eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind. If you simply say, “I shall breathe in experiencing rapture,” you create more interruptions in the mind and don’t experience rapture.

This is delicate training: you experience rapture as you breathe in and out.

After rapture comes pleasure. What distinguishes *pīti*, or rapture, from *sukha*, or pleasure? *Pīti* arises in anticipation of what lies ahead. Pleasure comes from experiencing what you anticipated.

⁵¹ Adapted from MN 118, §19.

The Traveler in the Desert

For instance, when you travel in a desert, you feel tired, thirsty, and dry as you look for water. You look forward to finding a place to drink. Then you see a person approaching, dripping with water, his hair and clothes wet and his face and eyes refreshed.

You might ask him, “Mister, I am also traveling through this desert and cannot find water. I am thirsty, but you are dripping wet and seem to have quenched your thirst. What happened?”

He would tell you that he found an oasis, a little pond or lake in the desert with fresh water. Seeing him and hearing his account, you look forward to reaching that lake. He might say, “If you continue to walk the way you are going now, you will come across this lake.” He arouses your anticipation and encourages you to move forward.

As you move forward, you can see birds flying toward a certain place, and your rapture increases. Farther on, you hear children playing, talking, laughing, and jumping into the water. Your rapture grows as you anticipate reaching it. Then, sure enough, you see this pond or lake in the desert.

You immediately jump in and drink plenty of water. If you find lotus roots, you wash and eat them. You swim and spend a lot of time in that water. Then you come out and relax on the bank. You may sit or stretch out your arms and legs. Your thirst is quenched, your tiredness is gone, and you are completely relaxed and happy. That is pleasure.

Rapture arose in anticipation; now you enjoy the pleasure itself.⁵²

Rapture arises as you move toward an anticipated pleasure. It increases gradually, step by step. There are five kinds of rapture.

⁵² Compare Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, IV.100.

The first kind of rapture is very quick, like the prick of a needle—not painful, but pleasant. As it increases, it pervades your body. You feel as though you are rising above the ground and then floating in the air. Then you have pleasure.

The traditional account distinguishes five forms of rapture. Minor rapture may make the body’s hairs rise. Momentary rapture is brief, like lightning. Showering rapture comes in waves. Uplifting rapture is more sustained; its traditional description includes levitation. Pervading rapture suffuses the body. The all-pervading form is identified as the one especially conducive to absorption. These descriptions concern differences in rapture; the most dramatic sensation does not necessarily indicate the deepest collectedness.⁵³

Ordinary rapture and pleasure differ from the spiritual forms, called *nirāmisā pīti* and *nirāmisā sukha*. Nirāmisā means unworldly, without greed or hatred. *Sāmisā* means with greed. For instance, in an ordinary state, without jhāna, joy, rapture, or pleasure will make you laugh, talk, kiss, hug, dance, and even cry with joy.⁵⁴

In meditation, rapture and pleasure arise through peaceful breathing. There is no excitement, no impulse to jump up and down. Everything becomes increasingly calm, relaxed, and peaceful, and the mind gains very good concentration.

This requires training, which is why the instruction says, “He trains thus.” While breathing in and out, you don’t use words or talk. There is just uninterrupted rapture. You have overcome many hindrances, and none of them is now in your way. Continue in the same way when pleasure arises, knowing it as you breathe in and out.

⁵³ Gunaratana, *The Jhanas in Theravada Buddhist Meditation*, chap. 3, “Rapture.”

⁵⁴ SN 36.31, “Nirāmisā Sutta.”

One who has attained full enlightenment does not have worldly pleasure.

Those who have not attained full enlightenment can have both worldly and unworldly pleasure. When they practice meditation and attain the jhānas, they can experience unworldly pleasure during that period. Once they come out of that state, they return to worldly pleasure.

Suppose you had a very peaceful sitting yesterday. The breath became quiet, and you felt comfortable throughout the body. Today you sit down expecting the same experience. You arrange the cushion in the same way and close your eyes, but the mind is restless. Soon you are comparing every breath with yesterday's breath. How much attention remains for the breath you are taking now? This comparison can occupy the whole sitting.

We can distinguish pleasure from the wish to possess it. We can know a pleasant experience without demanding that it continue, and recognize the desire that gathers around it. Yesterday you were content to sit. Today you may be impatient, checking whether the pleasant feeling has returned. See that impatience. The memory of a peaceful sitting has become a condition for agitation. This gives you something useful to understand about the mind.

Begin with what is present today. If the breath is rougher, know that. If the body is less comfortable, know that. You are still practicing mindfulness of breathing. You do not need to reproduce every detail of the previous sitting before practice can begin. Even your disappointment can be known. Look at how it affects your willingness to remain with this breath. As the demand for yesterday's experience weakens, give today's breathing your full attention.

When pleasure comes, continue the training that supports it. Let the mind settle, and remain aware as you breathe. There is no need to interrupt the experience to decide how it compares with another person's account or with a description you have read. Later, if it changes, you can understand why clinging to it brings disappointment. This is the subtle grief we will discuss shortly. We learn from the pleasure and from our response to its disappearance. Both bring us back to the work of knowing feeling.⁵⁵

Feeling and Perception

We are talking about mindfulness of feeling. Rapture and pleasure are feelings.

Here, feeling and perception are called mental formations because they condition the mind. When feeling arises, perception arises; when perception arises, thought arises; and when thought arises, desire arises. Desire leads to further thinking, which becomes sustained thinking. These activities arise with feeling and perception, which is why the two are called mental formations.

At this point, you recognize the rapture and pleasure you are experiencing.

Here, you experience rapture and pleasure physically and perceive them mentally.

You continue breathing in and out while knowing these mental formations.

Then the experience becomes even quieter, subtler, and more peaceful. Feeling and perception are the mental formations in the second tetrad of mindfulness of breathing. In the first tetrad, which concerns the body, we use the breath. We also use the breath in the second tetrad, but focus more on feeling and perception. Like the breath, feeling gradually becomes subtler until it reaches tranquility. This happens naturally.⁵⁶

⁵⁵ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 12, "Dealing with Distractions II," "Desire."

⁵⁶ MN 44, §§13–15.

How do we tranquilize them? Words disturb the mind. As we develop awareness, mindfulness, and concentration without words, the mind has the opportunity to experience tranquility.

When you hear or read the word “tranquilizing,” don’t assume that you deliberately bring about tranquility. Your deliberate effort is to avoid using words, concepts, and ideas and to keep the mind from wandering here and there. That is what you must train yourself to do. In this way you allow your mental formations, feeling and perception, to become tranquil naturally.

As you experience this tranquility, train yourself to keep distractions from disturbing it. Each of these steps involves training.

A Conversation about Feeling

At Rājagaha, while the Buddha was staying in the Bamboo Grove, the lay follower Visākha went to see the nun Dhammadinnā. After greeting her respectfully, he sat down and began asking questions. His questions concerned what we take ourselves to be, how clinging comes to an end, and the activities of breath, thought, perception, and feeling.

Visākha began by asking what the Buddha meant by identity. Dhammadinnā pointed to the five aggregates subject to clinging. An aggregate is a collection or group. The five are bodily form, the physical body; feeling, whether pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral; perception, recognition; mental formations, including intentions and other mental activities; and consciousness, awareness of an object. She then explained the craving through which this identity is maintained, the ending of that craving, and the noble eightfold path leading to its ending. How does experience become something we grasp as ourselves?

Visākha asked whether clinging was the same as the five aggregates or something separate from them. Dhammadinnā accepted neither alternative. Clinging is the desire and attachment directed toward those aggregates. This distinction allows us to examine experience more carefully. Feeling is present; attachment to feeling can also be present. We need to understand their relationship without treating feeling itself as a failure in practice.

As the conversation continued, Visākha asked about concentration. Dhammadinnā described a unified mind. She connected its development with the four foundations of mindfulness and the four right efforts: preventing unwholesome states, abandoning those already present, arousing wholesome states, and maintaining them. Repeatedly cultivating these qualities develops concentration.

Then Visākha asked about formations. Dhammadinnā distinguished bodily, verbal, and mental formations. In this particular explanation, breathing in and out is the bodily formation; applying and sustaining thought are the verbal formation; perception and feeling are the mental formation.

Why these distinctions? Breathing is bodily and bound up with the body. Thought prepares the way for speech: before we speak, the mind has already turned toward what we will say and given it further thought. Perception and feeling are mental and bound up with the mind.

Here, the term mental formations means feeling and perception. Earlier, the same conversation named feeling, perception, and the formations aggregate separately. Using the term this way does not combine those three aggregates into one. The meaning depends on the relationship being explained.

For breathing practice, the immediate subjects are feeling and perception. We are learning how experience feels and how it is recognized, including the pleasure and recognition present in a settled mind. We become acquainted with these mental activities as breathing continues. We can recognize them becoming calm, just as we can recognize their earlier disturbance.

Later, Visākha asked how many kinds of feeling there are. Dhammadinnā named three: pleasant, painful, and neither pleasant nor painful. Each can be experienced bodily or mentally. Feeling therefore includes more than bodily sensation, and it need not be a strong emotion that we can name. Something may be agreeable, disagreeable, or neither without becoming a long story about our life.

She also drew attention to change. Pleasant feeling is agreeable while it lasts, but a change in it can bring pain. Painful feeling hurts while it continues, yet a change in it can bring relief. With feeling that is neither pleasant nor painful, understanding makes a difference. Such feeling can be overlooked because it neither attracts nor repels us strongly. Even when it draws little notice, it remains something to understand.

Visākha went further. What tendencies lie beneath these feelings? Dhammadinnā connected pleasant feeling with the tendency toward desire, painful feeling with resistance, and neutral feeling with ignorance. But he then asked an essential question: does each tendency accompany every feeling of that kind? Her answer was no.

That qualification leaves room for the training. Pleasure need not always carry attachment. Pain need not always carry hostility. Neutrality need not always carry unawareness. The work is to understand and abandon the underlying tendency, rather than condemn a feeling merely for being pleasant or painful.

Dhammadinnā gave specific examples. In the first jhāna, pleasure and rapture accompany withdrawal from sensual desire and unwholesome states. That pleasure serves to abandon desire instead of nourishing it. She also described the sorrow that can arise when a practitioner longs for a liberation already realized by noble disciples. Its direction differs from resentment over a frustrated worldly demand. In the fourth jhāna, neither-painful-nor-pleasant feeling is accompanied by equanimity and purified mindfulness, rather than by the ignorance that can accompany ordinary indifference.

These examples show why we need to look beyond whether an experience is pleasant, painful, or neutral. We need to know what accompanies it, what supports it, and what is being relinquished through it. Simply calling something pleasant or painful cannot tell us all that. Careful observation helps us see the distinction.

Consider an ordinary period of your sitting. You are aware of the in-breath and the out-breath, and the feeling you experience is neither pleasant nor unpleasant. Nothing particularly attracts you or troubles you. This is neutral feeling. Because it makes no strong demand on your attention, you might pass over it while waiting for something more noticeable to happen.

But neutral feeling is still feeling. You can know it while continuing to breathe. You need not make the breath more pleasant or search for discomfort. Give attention to the experience you already have and recognize its neutral quality. Allow this recognition to remain simple, without turning it into a discussion in your mind.

Then perhaps a thought arises: nothing interesting is happening. You begin wondering when the sitting will end. Perhaps you listen for somebody to move or for the bell to ring. Now you want a change. See how that wanting differs from the neutral

feeling you were experiencing. The uneventful period of breathing and your dissatisfaction with it are not the same thing.

You do not have to assume that this dissatisfaction will arise. You may remain attentive without wanting anything more. But when wanting does arise, recognize it. Notice whether attention has left the breath to search for something else. When you let go of that search, you can return to the breath and know how the experience feels at that time.

Sometimes your attention may become vague, and you scarcely notice how the experience feels. This calls for renewed attention. Come back to the breath and recognize what is present. Knowing neutral feeling requires mindfulness, just as knowing pleasure or discomfort does. We can be attentive even when the experience is uneventful.

A neutral feeling may change, just as a pleasant or unpleasant feeling may change. Continue to observe. We are not trying to preserve neutrality or turn it into a special attainment. We are becoming familiar with feeling, including the quiet, ordinary experiences we so easily overlook. These, too, belong to our practice.⁵⁷

The conversation eventually reached liberation and nibbāna, the ending of suffering. When Visākha tried to carry his series of questions beyond that, Dhammadinnā reminded him of the purpose and completion of the holy life. She invited him to ask the Buddha about her explanation. Visākha did so, reporting their conversation. The Buddha praised Dhammadinnā's wisdom and confirmed that he would have answered in the same way.

⁵⁷ MN 44, Cūḷavedalla Sutta, discussion of the three feelings and their underlying tendencies.

We now return to the instruction on mindfulness of feeling, where the word bhikkhu means a Buddhist monk.⁵⁸

Ardent, Fully Aware, and Mindful

“I say that this is a certain feeling among feelings, namely, giving close attention to in-breathing and out-breathing. That is why on that occasion a bhikkhu abides contemplating feeling as feeling, ardent, fully aware, and mindful, having put away covetousness and grief for the world.”⁵⁹

This explains how we develop rapture, pleasure, tranquility, and undisturbed awareness of feeling. Giving attention to in-breathing and out-breathing is also called a feeling among feelings. When you breathe in and out, you cannot stop feeling the breath. It happens very naturally. Although it becomes subtler and subtler, even in the subtlest states it is a feeling.

To experience that feeling, you need special training. Be ardent: deeply committed to overcoming defilements. What are the defilements mentioned here? They are covetousness and grief.

Covetousness is the desire for something that belongs to somebody else. You need to overcome it.

Next, the instruction calls for full awareness. What are you fully aware of? You are aware of feeling and perception. This requires committed, dedicated attention.

The instruction also calls for mindfulness, which always means seeing something rise and fall. These feelings change so quickly that you cannot isolate them. But with full,

⁵⁸ MN 44, §§1–15, 22–31.

⁵⁹ MN 118, §25.

undivided attention, the mind becomes very sharp. Nothing is faster than the mind; it can see even these rapid changes. That seeing is called mindfulness.

You do this having put away covetousness and grief. What is grief for the world? Grief is *domanassa*, which means disappointment. When somebody passes away, you grieve because of attachment to that person. Attachment also brings grief when you lose something you love very dearly, something very close to your heart.

Here, grief for the world concerns yourself, not the outside world. You can grieve for something you lose within yourself. What do you lose? Your rapture, pleasure, and tranquility appear and disappear very quickly, and grief can arise each time. Whenever something you love, desire, and cling to changes and disappears, you experience grief. This is very subtle grief.

The First Jhāna

In the first jhāna you have overcome five hindrances, and naturally they are replaced by five mental factors, called jhānic factors. The five hindrances are greed, hatred, sleepiness and drowsiness, restlessness and worry, and doubt. Initial thought brings attention to the object; sustained thought maintains it. Together with joy or rapture, pleasure, and concentration, these are the five jhānic factors.

In jhāna, all five hindrances must be suppressed. They are not active in you at all.

Sometimes we can suppress the five hindrances without attaining jhāna. For example, when we listen to Dhamma wholeheartedly, with strong faith or confidence (*saddhā*), we pay attention to each word and its meaning. The hindrances subside for that time, giving us a reasonable degree of concentration. But this is not jhāna. To attain jhāna, we need to quiet the mind and keep it focused on a meditation object.

Rapture refreshes, pleasure satisfies, and concentration unifies. We are describing their work together in the concentrated mind. Initial and sustained thought here do not mean that we continue making speeches about the breath while meditating.

Remember the example of listening to Dhamma. For a time, you may be free from a particular worry because you are interested in what you hear. That helps you understand how a hindrance can subside. It does not by itself mean that all the conditions of the first jhāna are present. In the same way, the sign discussed earlier should be understood in relation to the whole practice.

Consider the bath-paste image explained below. Moisture permeates the whole mixture. In the same way, rapture and pleasure pervade the meditator's body. A brief pleasant feeling is not the full experience being described. The account of the first jhāna includes both the absence of the hindrances and the presence of its five factors. We study these distinctions so that our understanding can guide practice. During the sitting itself, continue to pay the quiet, undivided attention already described.⁶⁰

In the first jhāna, joy and happiness—pīti and sukha—pervade the entire mind and body. Although this is not a very high stage, one who enters it experiences mind and body working together, completely filled with that joy and happiness.

We can also think of bath powder stirred into a bathtub as water is added little by little. The powder becomes completely dissolved throughout the water. That is the kind of feeling the person has.

⁶⁰ Gunaratana, *The Jhanas in Theravada Buddhist Meditation*, chap. 3, “The Factors of the First Jhana” and “Perfecting the First Jhana.”

Three characteristics mark the purity of practice as we enter the first jhāna. What are they?

The first characteristic is that the mind is purified of obstructions, including the hindrances and ignorance. Once you overcome these obstructions, your mind is pure.

Second, through purification, the mind arrives at the center—a state of balance, or equipoise, that is the sign of tranquility. You cannot have tranquility without the mind being pure.

Third, having arrived at that point, you enter the first jhāna.

Looking again at the hindrances and the jhānic factors, we can identify ten characteristics: five hindrances are overcome, and five jhānic factors arise.

Four Images of Collectedness

The Buddha's discourse on mindfulness of the body, MN 119, explains the jhānas as part of developing awareness of the body. The story begins at Sāvatthī, where monks have gathered after their meal. They are discussing the great benefit of developing mindfulness of the body. The Buddha joins them, asks about their conversation, and then explains the practice in detail.

Breathing is part of this explanation, along with knowing bodily postures, being clearly aware of activities, examining the body's parts and elements, and contemplating its mortality. The same body that walks, eats, breathes, and changes is included in these descriptions of collectedness. Awareness of the body remains relevant as concentration deepens.

Four images show how rapture, pleasure, equanimity, and clarity enter into this training. Each describes a quality that reaches throughout the body.

The Buddha's traditional bath-powder image uses a kneaded paste. A bath attendant, or an apprentice, places powder in a metal basin, adds water gradually, and works the mixture together. The result is a ball of bathing paste moistened all the way through. It has no dry interior, yet it does not drip. The image is of a kneaded mass holding moisture throughout, rather than loose powder dissolved in a tub of water.

The Buddha relates this image to rapture and pleasure pervading the body in the first jhāna. They arise with seclusion from sensual desire and unwholesome states. The description includes applied thought, also called initial thought, and sustained thought. As moisture permeates the ball of paste, rapture and pleasure pervade the body.

For the second jhāna, the image changes to a deep pool supplied by a spring. Water does not flow into it from any direction, and the pool does not depend on rain to replenish it. Cool water rises within it and reaches every part of the pool. The refreshment comes from within.

Here applied and sustained thought have quieted, and the mind has become more settled. Rapture and pleasure remain, but the discourse now associates their arising with concentration. The pool is refreshed from within.

The third image is a pond with lotuses growing below the surface. These lotuses are born in the water and develop in it. Coolness reaches their roots and their tips; no part is left outside its influence. They remain immersed in the water.

In the third jhāna, pleasure remains while rapture has faded. Equanimity, mindfulness, and clear awareness are present. Pleasure is experienced more quietly, as cool water continues to reach every part of the submerged lotuses.

The fourth image leaves the pool behind. A person sits with the body, including the head, covered by a white cloth. In the corresponding description, the body is pervaded by a mind that is clear and purified.

At this point pleasure and pain have been relinquished, and the earlier movements of joy and grief have subsided. The feeling is neither painful nor pleasant. Equanimity purifies mindfulness. The emphasis has shifted from pleasurable feeling to the clarity and balance of the mind. Like the covering cloth, clarity reaches throughout the body.

After each description, the discourse returns to the development of mindfulness of the body. With sustained, earnest practice, preoccupations connected with household life are relinquished and the mind settles inwardly. The images show how body and mind develop together through this practice. We study those qualities while continuing to know what is actually present in our own practice.⁶¹

⁶¹ MN 119, §§1–21.

Chapter 5

Knowing and Freeing the Mind



Knowing the Mind with Its Contents

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing the mind.” He trains thus:

“I shall breathe out experiencing the mind.”

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in gladdening the mind.” He trains thus: “I shall breathe out gladdening the mind.”

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in concentrating the mind.” He trains thus: “I shall breathe out concentrating the mind.”

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in liberating the mind.” He trains thus: “I shall breathe out liberating the mind.”⁶²

⁶² MN 118, §20.

These sentences are easy to read, but their meaning is profound and very useful in practice.

The first instruction is, “I shall breathe in experiencing the mind.” How do we do this? We do not experience the mind simply by talking about it, reading about it, or listening to talks about it. We must give it our full attention—pure, clean attention. We know the mind through its contents; without them, we cannot experience it.

This mind is called *citta*. The term points to the variety of things the mind does and the various mental states it experiences.

When the mind has greed, lust, or desire, we understand, “This is the mind with desire.” When greed fades away, you know at that moment that the mind is free from greed.

We may also notice the change in the opposite order. At first, the mind is free from greed. Then the eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, or mind encounters its object—a sight, sound, smell, taste, touch, or mind object—and greed can arise. When it does, we recognize, “This mind is with greed.” In this way, we know the mind with greed present.

We can use words such as craving, greed, lust, attachment, love, liking, inclination, and so forth to describe this state of mind. But when explaining something, we cannot put all these synonyms into one sentence, as though reciting a dictionary. So we use only one word. That is why we use the Pali word *rāga*, or desire, to encompass these terms in this context.

As you meditate, pay total attention to see how desire works. What does it do to your mind? What does it do to you? Are you happy or unhappy? You can see the impact, the result of desire or craving. Then desire fades away until it is no longer present.

The mind can also have the opposite of desire: hatred or anger. Ordinarily, hatred comes and goes. When we encounter a situation through our eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and so on, hatred or anger can arise. At that time you know, “This mind is with anger.”

When we become mindful, practice mettā, cultivate patience, and develop understanding, that hatred slowly fades away. Then we know the mind is free from hatred. That is how you know the mind.

Confusion can suddenly arise through seeing, hearing, and so on. You cannot make a decision. The mind is not very clear. We hear people say, “Oh, I’m confused now.” At that time we understand that the mind is confused. As we try to understand what is happening, develop insight, practice mindfulness, and observe how things arise and pass away, wisdom arises and confusion fades away. Then we know the mind is free from confusion.

This is how we experience the mind. As we breathe in and breathe out, we experience that particular state of mind.

Knowing the Condition of the Mind

The Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta describes how to know the mind through its changing conditions. We know when desire is present in the mind and when it is absent. We give the same careful attention to hatred and delusion, and to their absence. We learn to recognize both the difficulty and freedom from it. The absence deserves attention too.

The discourse continues beyond these familiar three. It includes a contracted mind, weighed down by dullness, and a scattered mind, stirred by agitation. It also distinguishes an exalted mind, developed through deep concentration, from an unexalted mind

occupied with ordinary sense experience. States of ordinary sense experience can be surpassed. In the traditional commentary, the refined meditative states are called unsurpassed in comparison with ordinary sense experience. This does not mean that they constitute final liberation. The discourse also asks us to know a concentrated mind and one without concentration, a liberated mind and one not liberated. These descriptions widen the inquiry. We are learning about the condition of the mind as a whole, as well as the particular thought or object that occupies it.⁶³

Desire and concentration, for example, tell us different things about the mind. Desire concerns what affects it; concentration concerns how collected it is. The instruction is to know the relevant condition accurately. We do not make a contracted or scattered mind into a settled one merely by choosing a favorable description. Nor does recognizing that concentration is absent mean that observation has failed. That absence is one of the conditions the Buddha explicitly tells us to know.

The sutta then asks us to attend to arising and disappearance, and to both together. Knowing a state therefore means more than giving it a name. A concentrated state can arise and pass away. So can a distracted state. We follow these changes instead of treating either state as a fixed identity. This is how the apparently simple act of knowing the mind remains connected with insight.

In the same discourse, the contemplation of feeling is presented separately. We recognize pleasant, painful, and neither-painful-nor-pleasant feeling. We also distinguish feelings connected with worldly experience from those not connected with it. The quality of feeling and the condition of mind are closely related, but the instructions distinguish

⁶³ Soma, *The Way of Mindfulness*, “The Contemplation of Consciousness.”

them. A description of how an experience feels does not, by itself, tell us everything about the mind experiencing it.

Mindfulness is established for knowing and remembering what is present, while clinging is relinquished. This repeated refrain reminds us that we can recognize the mind and its conditions without claiming them as our own. When a condition changes, observation can continue.

The same refrain asks us to contemplate internally, externally, and in both ways. Mind and its changing conditions are objects of mindfulness. We can approach both a quiet moment and a troubled moment with the intention to understand rather than cling.⁶⁴

The Breath as the Default

Remember that the breath is our default meditation object—the object we return to when nothing else needs our attention. Breathing continues whether you are aware of it or not. When a certain mental state arises, it is the invader. You immediately become aware of it.

When anger arises, you can focus the mind on your anger while you are breathing. While anger is the object of your attention, you are not focusing on the breath. If you return your attention to the breath, anger slowly weakens. If you want to understand anger clearly and use it as an object, focus your mind on that experience. You can do the same when experiencing compassion, and so forth.

Let the breath go in and out as it normally does. When there is nothing else to attend to, return to the breath. At the beginning of the *Ānāpānasati Sutta*, you recognize a long inhalation as a long inhalation and a long exhalation as a long exhalation. No other mental state, such as greed or hatred, is mentioned—only the breath.

⁶⁴ MN 10, §§32–35.

Then some defilement invades the mind. It becomes more prominent than the breath, but breathing continues. You take care of this invader. When it disappears, you return to the breath.

For example, while you are following the breath, you remember a conversation in which somebody criticized you. Soon you are preparing the answer you wish you had given. You remember another occasion when that person behaved in the same way, and then another. You may know very well that you are thinking, yet the argument continues. At that moment, look at what has happened to your attention. The conversation has ended, but you are carrying it on during the sitting.

The anger present now can be known directly. You can recognize the mind's resentment and the discomfort that accompanies it. There is no need to settle the whole disagreement in order to know that anger is present. Notice the difference between attending to that condition and preparing another reply. The reply takes you back into the conversation. Recognizing resentment brings attention to the mind you are experiencing now.

When a distraction becomes dominant, briefly observe its nature, strength, and duration. When it loses its hold, return to breathing. This is a short, direct observation; explaining it takes longer than doing it. You do not have to recite these instructions during meditation.⁶⁵

If anger continues to occupy the mind, understand its danger and cultivate mettā. Meanwhile, breathing continues naturally. You need not divide your attention equally

⁶⁵ For the brief examination of a distraction's nature, strength, and duration, see Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 12, "Dealing with Distractions II," opening discussion.

between breath and anger, or keep testing whether you can attend to both at once. Attend to the difficulty that has become prominent. When you can leave it, return to the familiar experience of breathing in and breathing out.

While the breath is your clear object, remain with it. When a mental state takes over, recognize it and deal with it appropriately. Then resume the breathing practice. The same distinction applies to rumination, or repeatedly going over the same thoughts: knowing that an argument is continuing gives you an opportunity to let it go.

Initial and Sustained Thought

The second step of the noble eightfold path, *sammā saṅkappa*, is right thinking. Thinking is sometimes called saṅkappa, sometimes vitakka. In jhānic concentration practice, it is called vitakka. I think the word saṅkappa is used particularly in the noble eightfold path. In general, they are the same.

Vitakka is the initial application of thought, or the moment when a thought first arises. There are six kinds: three unwholesome and three wholesome. The three unwholesome are thoughts of sensual pleasures, thoughts of hatred or anger, and thoughts of cruelty. The three wholesome are thoughts of renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness.⁶⁶

From the beginning of jhāna practice, we learn to abandon sensual pleasures temporarily, at least for that moment. We give up anger, sleepiness and drowsiness, restlessness and worry, and doubt. Giving up desire and anger is especially important, and we must also abandon thoughts of cruelty.

⁶⁶ MN 19, §2.

Vicāra, or sustained thought, means maintaining the wholesome state. At the very beginning we give up the unwholesome states, and we maintain the three kinds of wholesome thought throughout the entire period of jhāna. We do not forget. Whenever anger arises, we immediately recognize it and let it go.

Applied and sustained thought also describe two functions of attention in concentration. Applied thought directs the mind to its object; sustained thought keeps the mind engaged there. These are ways of bringing attention to the object and keeping it there, not of talking to ourselves about it. The same terms can occur in ordinary thinking, but their function in jhāna is specifically wholesome and directed toward concentration.⁶⁷

Making the Effort

When you notice a mental formation arising, your job is to see whether it is wholesome or unwholesome. If it is unwholesome, immediately recognize the danger, pain, and suffering associated with it.

Anger, greed, and jealousy are mental formations, as are the other thoughts that arise in the mind. When these formations are unwholesome, pain and suffering arise immediately with them. This is the nature of dependent origination: when this arises, that arises. Anger brings pain, and so does greed.

When the thought of letting go arises, peace arises. When we abandon greed, we experience peace at that moment. When we abandon hatred, we experience peace and friendliness. When we have a thought of compassion, we have peace.

⁶⁷ Gunaratana, *The Jhanas in Theravada Buddhist Meditation*, chap. 3, “Applied Thought” and “Sustained Thought.”

When we see the results of these mental states, we can decide which to maintain and which to abandon. We do not want to hold on to what brings pain and suffering, so we make an effort to let it go as soon as it arises. This is right effort in the noble eightfold path.

First, when unwholesome states are absent, we make an effort to prevent them from arising and to maintain our wholesome state of mind. But when our effort is not yet strong enough, a habitual unwholesome state may arise again. We have developed these habits over a lifetime: getting angry, feeling jealous, treating others as rivals, and so forth. Whether we intended to or not, we have cultivated them. Now we work to prevent them from arising.

Unfortunately, your first effort may not succeed. An unwholesome mental state may overcome your wholesome state and invade your mind. Then you make an effort to get rid of it. That is the second effort: abandoning.

Then you make the third effort: deliberately and mindfully cultivating wholesome mental states. The fourth effort is to sustain them. This is how we need to deal with mental formations. Cultivating and maintaining these states does not happen automatically. We must apply the fourfold effort of the noble eightfold path.⁶⁸

Remember, in our practice, the noble eightfold path is our rescue, our guardian, and our refuge. We always return to it and use the appropriate step to deal with an unwholesome mental state.

⁶⁸ SN 45.8, definition of right effort; see also MN 62, §18, on loving-friendliness as a response to ill will.

Taking Care of Anger

When resentment or anger arises, your attention drifts from the breath and stays with that disturbance. To take care of it, you need to understand its nature and disadvantages.

Anger always pulls you down, making you very uncomfortable and robbing you of peace and happiness. See the danger of anger.

Return to the mettā practice you did at the beginning of meditation. Practice mettā for a while, until the anger fades away. Then it will be easy to return to the breath. You must overcome anger. That is the second effort.

Let us follow all four efforts through that same sitting. At first you are attending to breathing, and anger is absent. You remember that dwelling on a certain quarrel usually disturbs you. So you give careful attention to the breath instead of deliberately rehearsing the quarrel. This is prevention. You are supporting the conditions in which anger has less opportunity to arise.

Then the memory appears anyway. Perhaps your breath becomes shallow or fast before an angry thought arises. Notice the bodily response you actually experience. You need not wait for a thought to become a complete sentence before becoming attentive. Let the breath continue naturally as you recognize the agitation. If anger is present, see how it has disturbed the peace of the sitting. This gives your effort a direction: you want to abandon the anger.

Now cultivate mettā. You can begin with the wish that you and the other person be free from hostility. Attend to that wish with sincerity, even if warmth is slow to come. A wholesome intention can help displace the unwholesome one and make room for mindfulness. This is the effort to arouse what is wholesome. Breathing gives you a

familiar place to return to; mettā addresses the resentment that has drawn you away from it.

When the anger weakens, the work continues. Support the friendliness and patience that have become possible. Allow the mind to remain with the breath, and take care with the thoughts you encourage. If you begin rehearsing the quarrel again to test whether you are still angry, you may renew the disturbance. Give the wholesome state the attention it needs to continue. This is the fourth effort, maintaining what has arisen.

You can see these efforts working together. Prevent unwholesome states where you can, abandon those that have appeared, cultivate what is helpful, and sustain it. If resentment returns, apply the appropriate effort again. We are working with habits developed over a long time. Each time, understand which condition is present and which kind of effort will help.⁶⁹

Gladdening and Concentrating the Mind

Then what happens? “I shall breathe in gladdening the mind.” The mind doesn’t become glad for no reason. As greed, confusion, and other unwholesome states fade away, it becomes glad. With that gladness we breathe in, and with that gladness we breathe out.

Then he trains thus: “I shall breathe in concentrating the mind.” Concentration cannot arise while these unwholesome states occupy the mind. As we let go of them, the mind becomes concentrated, and we breathe in and out with that concentration.

We can begin to understand this connection during any sitting. Suppose you sit down worrying about work you have left unfinished. You follow a breath, but soon you are

⁶⁹ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, online early edition, chap. 11, “Dealing with Distractions I,” “Canceling One Thought with Another.”

deciding what to do first, how long it will take, and whether you will have enough time. Again and again the mind leaves the breath to continue this planning. You see how the worry keeps it unsettled.

Then you recognize that you have set aside this period for meditation. The work can be attended to afterward. For now, you let go of rehearsing it and give attention to breathing. When the worry loosens, notice the relief. A moment ago the mind was occupied with all those demands. Now it can remain with something simple. You know the breath without continually going away to arrange the rest of the day.

That relief gives you an opportunity to understand how abandoning a disturbance supports gladness. You do not have to give yourself a speech about being happy. Know the change that has occurred. As gladness develops, the body can become more tranquil. With this ease, the mind can settle more steadily on the breath. The instructions to gladden and concentrate the mind are closely connected.

Keep attending as you breathe in and out. There may be less difficulty remaining with the next breath. Allow that steadiness to develop. If you immediately begin asking what stage you have reached, you give the mind another subject to pursue. Soon you may be thinking about concentration instead of knowing the breathing. Recognize that change and return to the practice.

We still need effort. Letting the mind settle does not mean leaving it unattended. Continue to know the breath. When attention slips away, bring it back. When it remains, sustain that attention without introducing something else to occupy it. You are learning what helps the mind stay collected and what disturbs it.

Such an encouraging change does not by itself establish that you have attained jhāna. Here you can understand something directly: the mind burdened by worry has difficulty settling, while freedom from that worry makes steadiness possible. Notice how the disturbance was relinquished and how the mind responded. This prepares us to understand the next instruction, liberating the mind.

Remembering How the Mind Became Free

How can we liberate the mind?

We must remember how the mind became free from greed, hatred, delusion, and so forth. How did that happen? Only then can we practice this aspect of mindfulness of breathing. That is why the Buddha said, “I do not say that there is the development of mindfulness of breathing for one who is forgetful, who is not fully aware.”⁷⁰

We need to remember the sequence: how defilements arose and how they faded away. Recalling what happened and how we let go of those states strengthens our resolve and encourages further effort.

That is why, on that occasion, a bhikkhu abides contemplating mind as mind, ardent, fully aware, and mindful, having put away covetousness and grief for the world. “Ardent” is another word for the effort we make to overcome our defilements. We must be fully aware. In mindfulness of breathing, we should not let the mind keep wandering away from the practice. It must remain with the meditation.

What is covetousness? Covetousness is the desire or greed to possess something belonging to somebody else. What is grief? We want something that belongs to somebody else, and we don’t get it. Then grief, or disappointment, arises.

⁷⁰ MN 118, §26.

Here, “the world” means this one-fathom body with its consciousness—our own five aggregates. Covetousness and grief arise within this world, as do mindfulness and awareness. This is the world we examine in our practice.⁷¹

Liberating the Mind

What do we liberate the mind from?

“Liberating the mind from greed, I shall breathe in.” He trains himself: “Liberating the mind from greed, I shall breathe out.”

“Liberating the mind from hatred, I breathe in. Liberating the mind from hatred, I breathe out.”

“Liberating the mind from delusion, I breathe in. Liberating the mind from delusion, I breathe out.”

“Liberating the mind from pride, I breathe in. Liberating the mind from pride, I breathe out.”⁷²

I mentioned greed, hatred, and delusion. But what about pride? How can pride arise while we are practicing mindfulness of breathing?

Pride can arise when we think, “I am a meditator. Others are not meditators. Therefore I am superior; they are inferior.” These defilements can sneak into our mind at any moment when we become unmindful. They are waiting for an opportunity to invade the mind.

Then there is wrong view. Sixty-two wrong views are mentioned in one sutta, and ten are mentioned in various suttas. These include the views that giving, offering, and sharing

⁷¹ AN 4.45; also SN 2.26.

⁷² These are applications of the instruction to liberate the mind in MN 118, §20; the expanded formulas are not verbatim quotations from that discourse.

have no result and that neither this world nor the next exists. They also include the view that there is no mother—meaning that there is no benefit in supporting one’s mother—and no benefit in supporting one’s father. There is also the erroneous belief that dishonesty and cruelty have no harmful consequences. We might think, “There is no harm in deceiving someone, as long as I get what I want and no one finds out.” Such a view overlooks the effects of our actions on others and on our own minds.

Other examples include ruling out possibilities beyond our ordinary experience, whether these concern how beings come into existence or the abilities they may possess.

There can also be many other wrong views involving belief in extremes.⁷³

Then there are uncertainty, doubt, and confusion. There is wholesome doubt and unwholesome doubt. Wholesome doubt is questioning that helps us understand the Dhamma. Unwholesome doubt means never being satisfied with any answer. Chronic skeptics are not satisfied, no matter how correct the answers to their questions are. They simply try to ask another question and always remain uncertain. This chronic skepticism is a defilement.

We must understand this distinction carefully. Suppose you are unsure whether an instruction asks you to change the breath or simply to know the breath as it is. That is a question about what to do. Asking for clarification can help you practice correctly. You do not have to pretend to understand an instruction that is unclear to you.

Notice exactly where the difficulty lies. Perhaps you understand the words but do not know how to apply them. Keep that point in mind so that you can ask about it when you

⁷³ For the two traditional lists, see DN 1, Brahmajāla Sutta, and MN 117, §5.

speak with a teacher. A precise question makes it easier to explain what is troubling you and receive useful guidance.

Now consider a different situation. You know what the instruction asks, but while sitting you keep debating whether to follow it. Perhaps you should try another method. Perhaps you should stop and read more. You decide to continue, then begin the same debate again. Meanwhile, several breaths pass with scarcely any attention. The mind has become occupied with wavering rather than with the practice you intended to do.

At that point, know the wavering itself. What is happening in the mind? Notice its uncertainty and how it keeps attention moving from one possibility to another. You need not settle every question about meditation before recognizing this present condition. See when it is strong and when it begins to loosen. When you can leave the debate, return to breathing.

Returning to the breath does not erase a question that genuinely needs an answer. You can take it up at an appropriate time. But repeating a question throughout the sitting may not help you answer it. Sometimes we go over the same uncertainty while making no effort to examine it or listen to an explanation. Then doubt continues to obstruct the practice.

Look at what your inquiry is doing. Does it help you understand an instruction and examine your experience, or does it keep you circling around the same uncertainty? Be willing to listen carefully to an explanation and test your understanding in practice. In this way, inquiry helps you learn. Recognizing the hindrance of doubt helps you stop feeding indecision and give attention to the practice before you.

Then there are stiffness and rigidity. Instead of relaxing and easing into meditation, we can become stiff. That, too, is a defilement. We try to liberate the mind from stiffness, another part of sleepiness. Then there are agitation and restlessness. These are hindrances.

Hindrances are temporary. You can overcome them for a time by attaining jhānas during meditation. With faith in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha, we can also overcome them temporarily. But they can arise again. Agitation is one hindrance; stiffness and torpor (drowsiness) are another; doubt is another; greed is another; and so forth.

The Roots Below the Ground

As long as fetters remain, hindrances arise. Hindrances are like plants above the ground. Fetters are like the network of roots below. That network continually sends up sprouts and shoots that become new plants.

Below them is another layer of defilements, called influxes—mental impurities deeply rooted in the mind. Beneath those lies yet another layer, called anusaya, or underlying tendencies. When we meditate, we may experience agitation, sleepiness, stiffness, torpor, and so forth. We can overcome them during meditation, but when we come out of it, they can flood our mind.

When we meditate, we temporarily liberate the mind from these defilements. One day we will be able to overcome them so completely that they never return. This is what we do in mindfulness of the mind: liberate the mind.

When these defilements arise during an in-breath, we work to let them go. We breathe out with the mind free from them, not letting them arise again as long as we remain mindful.

In mindfulness of breathing, we use the breath to keep the mind focused so that these distractions—the defilements—will not invade it.

Think again of the plants and their roots. If the ground is clear today, we can see that no shoots are present. We cannot conclude from that alone that every root has gone. In the same way, you may finish a sitting without anger and then become angry when somebody speaks harshly. The earlier peace was real. The later anger shows that more work remains. Understanding both experiences helps you continue without exaggerating the first or becoming discouraged by the second.

What can you learn during the peaceful period? Recall how the disturbance ended. Perhaps you stopped rehearsing a grievance and developed friendliness. Perhaps attention became steady, and the old concern lost its urgency. You know the difference between the agitated mind and the mind released from that agitation. Remembering this gives you a practical basis for the next effort. It also allows you to recognize the mind when the familiar disturbance begins again.

Concentration can suspend the defilements. Wisdom is needed to uproot them. Insight prepares the way for the wisdom of the noble path—the liberating understanding that arises at awakening. Defilements cut off by that wisdom cannot return. A quiet sitting alone does not establish that this has happened.⁷⁴

⁷⁴ For the distinction between insight and the liberating wisdom of the noble path, see Gunaratana, *The Jhanas in Theravada Buddhist Meditation*, chap. 5, “The Way of Wisdom” and “The Two Vehicles.”

For the present, continue to understand your changing experience. You need not wait for a bright light. The breath changes, a thought appears, irritation weakens, and peace becomes possible. These are experiences you can know in your own practice. Notice also the wish to hold on to a peaceful state. When that wish produces fresh uneasiness, you can see why the freedom we seek must go deeper than another pleasant sitting.

This is why we keep practicing after a good meditation. The peace encourages us, and the return of a difficulty tells us where attention and effort are still needed. For now, be accurate about what you know: this hindrance is absent, this one has returned, and this is how the mind responds to the training.

Rumination and Insight

You cannot stop the mind, but you can become aware of what is happening in it. The mind itself changes so quickly that the Buddha said he could not give an example, a simile, to illustrate the speed of its changes. Therefore, if you deliberately try to stop it, you will naturally end up frustrated.⁷⁵

In insight meditation, we see impermanence, the most prominent feature of everything. We recognize arising, reaching a peak, and passing away. Ordinarily, these three mind moments pass too quickly for us to see them clearly, even taken together. We might think that together they would be coarse enough to notice, but even this is difficult. Distinguishing each moment separately is harder still.

In insight meditation, however, the mind becomes sharp and clear, free from hindrances and disturbances. It can then become aware of these mind moments. This is what we experience through mindfulness.

⁷⁵ AN 1.48.

Mental and physical processes continue, but the mind remains perfectly peaceful, undisturbed by ripples or waves of agitation. To bring the mind to that level, you must get rid of defilements: greed, hatred, delusion, jealousy, fear, tension, anxiety, and worries. All these things must vanish from the mind.

Changes are still taking place within the mind, but it has no object to hold on to and remains calm, relaxed, and peaceful. That is all the mind experiences in this state. To reach it, our greed, hatred, and delusion must certainly subside. Even if they subside only temporarily, we may experience a certain degree of peace.

In insight meditation, we may find ourselves going over the same thoughts again and again. We do not need to push these thoughts away or keep following them. Instead, we observe them mindfully. If greed, hatred, or delusion is present, we recognize it and work on letting it go. We can then return to the breath with a clearer understanding of what has been occupying the mind.

This is something we practice repeatedly. Each time we recognize that the mind has wandered, we have another opportunity to understand it and let go. Mindfulness of breathing is a lifelong practice. We begin life with the breath and end life with the breath. For as long as we breathe, we can continue cultivating mindfulness.

We breathe thousands of times every day and millions of times throughout our lives. We try to breathe mindfully as much as we can and to simplify our lives so that we have time to pay attention to the breath. In this way, we can make the breathing that continues throughout our lives part of our meditation.

Confidence Tested in Practice

A willingness to practice can come before complete certainty. You do not have to abandon every conviction or accept every description before beginning. Have enough trust in the training to try it carefully, and give it enough time for the result to become known. This kind of confidence leaves room for examination. It asks for sincere engagement rather than immediate agreement with everything you read.

Understanding an explanation, putting it into practice, and realizing its result are different tasks. Words can guide us, but they cannot do the practice for us. Through patient effort, we come to know from experience what the instruction describes. A brief or halfhearted trial is not enough to judge the value of a path that works with deeply established habits of mind. Concentration and wisdom support this investigation together. The purpose is freedom from suffering, and that calls for a commitment beyond wishing for an impressive sitting.⁷⁶

⁷⁶ Gunaratana, *Beyond Mindfulness in Plain English*, chap. 1, 1–7.

Chapter 6

Impermanence and Letting Go



He trains thus: “I shall breathe in contemplating impermanence. I shall breathe out contemplating impermanence.”

“I shall breathe in contemplating fading away. I shall breathe out contemplating fading away.”

“I shall breathe in contemplating cessation. I shall breathe out contemplating cessation.”

“I shall breathe in contemplating relinquishment. I shall breathe out contemplating relinquishment.”⁷⁷

⁷⁷ Adapted from MN 118, §21.

Impermanence means that what arises passes away. These are its two aspects: arising and passing away. We cannot speak of impermanence in something that does not exist, or in something that exists permanently.

We can see this in the breath. The in-breath arises and passes away, and so does the out-breath. As we breathe in and out, we contemplate their impermanence.

Whenever we use the word impermanence, we must always understand that what we are observing has a beginning and an end. Together, these show impermanence. There is nothing in the world that is permanent. Whatever arises is impermanent.

We can see impermanence from the moment we sit to meditate and focus on the breath. The breath comes and goes; its changing nature is already there to be observed.

Within this process, we can recognize three phases: something arises, reaches its peak, and passes away. These are the three characteristics through which we see impermanence.

You do not have to attain jhāna to see impermanence. But when you attain jhāna, your awareness or understanding of impermanence is deeper, clearer, sharper, and more pointed. That is the advantage of attaining jhāna.

Fading Away

The next instruction is: “I shall breathe in contemplating fading away.” Before something disappears, it gradually fades away, though this fading occurs at an extremely high speed. Then it suddenly disappears. Arising, fading away, and disappearing make up the complete process of impermanence.

As we breathe in, the breath's original power fades. When that power is lost, we see the breath's impermanence. The same fading occurs during the out-breath. Gradually, the breath disappears, completing the process of impermanence.

To understand what we mean by original power, take a rock and throw it into the air, vertically or horizontally. Its power gradually diminishes, and then it falls. We call its initial velocity its original power.

The same applies to the spiritual faculties: faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom. If you do not maintain them, their strength dwindles and fades away. The rock's motion illustrates how original power becomes weaker and weaker because of impermanence, until it comes to an end.

Cessation and Relinquishment

The next instruction is: "I shall breathe in contemplating cessation." When something disappears, it ceases, leaving nothing behind. "I shall breathe out contemplating cessation." One breath must cease for another to arise.

"I shall breathe in contemplating relinquishment." Relinquishment means letting go. When something ceases, we have no desire to hold on to it. In liberating the mind, we relinquish whatever greed, hatred, delusion, and so on may be present.

Impermanence, fading away, cessation, and relinquishment do not refer to something abstract. They refer to the five aggregates: form, feeling, perception, mental or volitional formations, and consciousness. That is what we must remember when we contemplate impermanence. Impermanence doesn't exist in a vacuum. Material things, feelings, and the other aggregates are impermanent because they have a beginning and an end. They fade away, cease, and are relinquished.

These changes happen naturally, depending on causes and conditions. Whatever arises fades away and disappears; there is no one directing the process or giving orders.

Rāhula Learns to Let Go

One morning, while the Buddha was staying at Jeta's Grove near Sāvattthī, he set out for alms. Rāhula followed him. The Buddha turned and gave him an instruction about the body. Whatever material form he considered—past, present, or future, within himself or outside, near or far—he should understand it without claiming it as his possession, his identity, or his self.

Rāhula asked whether this applied only to material form. The Buddha included feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness as well. Nothing in the five aggregates was to be exempted from this examination. Rāhula turned back from the alms round and sat beneath a tree, holding his body upright and establishing mindfulness. When Sāriputta saw him sitting there, he encouraged him to develop mindfulness of breathing. Later, after coming out of his seclusion, Rāhula went to the Buddha and asked how this practice should be cultivated to yield its great benefit.⁷⁸

The answer did not begin with the length of a breath. It began with the elements. The solid parts of the body, such as bones and teeth, were considered in terms of earth. Its fluids, such as blood, tears, and saliva, were considered in terms of water. Bodily warmth and digestion were considered in terms of fire. The movements of air, including breathing, were considered in terms of air. Openings and spaces in the body were considered in terms of the space element, the quality of openness.

⁷⁸ MN 62, §§1–7.

Each description brought Rāhula back to the same point. Earth within the body and earth outside it belong to the same element. The boundary that makes us speak of “my body” does not give the earth element within the body a separate, permanent self. The same examination applies to water, fire, air, and space. The breath, which feels so intimate, is included in this contemplation. We recognize these qualities and let attachment to them fade.⁷⁹

Then the Buddha used the image in a different way. The elements became examples of steadiness. Earth receives clean things and dirty things. People place waste, blood, and other unpleasant substances on it, but the earth does not become disgusted. Water washes things that are clean and things that are unclean. Fire burns both. Air blows over both. We are asked to develop the same kind of steadiness, so that agreeable and disagreeable contacts do not occupy the mind completely.

Consider how much of a sitting we can spend reacting to contact. Something pleasant appears, and we want it to remain. Something disagreeable appears, and we resist it. The element similes show how we can experience contact without letting its appeal or unpleasantness take over the whole mind.

Space provides another image. The discourse describes it as having no place where it is established. Rāhula is invited to cultivate a similar freedom from being caught. The similes work together: earth, water, fire, and air are not distressed by what they meet, and space has no fixed resting place. This prepares the mind to know experience without immediately fastening itself to it.⁸⁰

⁷⁹ MN 62, §§8–12.

⁸⁰ MN 62, §§13–17.

The Buddha also gave Rāhula specific qualities to develop. Loving-friendliness counters ill will. Compassion counters the impulse to hurt. Appreciative joy counters discontent. Equanimity counters aversion. Contemplating the unattractive aspect of the body counters lust, and recognizing impermanence counters the conceit of being an enduring “I.” With these qualities, our steadiness is warm and discerning. A mind can be even and also friendly. It can remain balanced and also respond with compassion.⁸¹

Only then does the discourse set out the sixteen instructions of mindfulness of breathing. Knowing a long or short breath belongs within this wider training of attention. So do calming the breath, experiencing joy and happiness, knowing the mind, and contemplating impermanence and relinquishment. The instruction given during the alms round has not been left behind. Breath practice continues the examination of the aggregates without taking them as an enduring self.

The practice of meditation also accompanied the Buddha to the end of his life. His final hours show the depth of his mastery. Before his passing, he entered the first jhāna and progressed through the second, third, and fourth. He then moved through the four immaterial attainments, deep meditative absorptions beyond the perception of material form, and entered the cessation of perception and feeling. Ānanda thought he had died, but Anuruddha explained that he was still in a meditative attainment. Emerging from this state, the Buddha returned through the attainments in reverse order to the first jhāna. He then progressed once more through the second, third, and fourth jhānas. After emerging

⁸¹ MN 62, §§18–23.

from the fourth jhāna, he attained parinibbāna—his final passing away, with no further rebirth.⁸²

The instruction to Rāhula brings us back to how this training begins: by knowing the breath that is occurring now. We notice an inhalation, experience its changing sensations, and recognize its ending. We observe the exhalation in the same way. Whenever attention wanders, we return and begin again. Through repeated practice, we become familiar with the breath and with the fact that each breath comes to an end.

The Buddha explained that, when mindfulness of breathing is developed in this way, “even the final in-breaths and out-breaths are known as they cease, not unknown.” Rāhula was learning a practice whose benefits could extend to the very end of life. We begin with the ordinary breaths we experience each day, gradually developing the steadiness and clarity to know their changing nature and let them pass. The instruction points toward meeting even the final breaths with awareness.⁸³

Practicing the Final Four Instructions

Should we think about all four instructions during meditation? I do not think so. But we must understand the contemplation of impermanence, which is at the heart of all four. We remember these four pairs of instructions because they describe what we experience.

We definitely experience the impermanence of the breath. While breathing in, we experience the impermanence of feelings. We experience it in perception and in whatever thought arises. We also experience the changing nature of consciousness while meditating.

⁸² DN 16, Mahāparinibbāna Sutta, part 6, §§9–11, in the translation by Sister Vajirā and Francis Story.

⁸³ MN 62, §§24–30.

Similarly, we experience the fading away of form, feeling, perception, volitions—or intentions—and consciousness. We experience the cessation of form—here, the breath—and of feeling, perception, and so forth. We experience relinquishment, or letting go. Something arises and disappears. We should not hanker after it. Let it go. This is what we do.

Let us take something very simple. An in-breath begins. Its touch becomes clear, changes, and is no longer there in the same way. We do not have to tell the breath to change. We stay with it long enough to recognize what it is doing. If we spend the whole time saying “impermanent, impermanent,” we may be paying more attention to the words than to the breath. The instruction reminds us where to look; the breathing gives us something to see.

Perhaps this breath feels especially comfortable. We want the next one to be just as comfortable. Now we have something else to notice: wanting. The pleasant experience has changed, but the mind is trying to continue it. Can we recognize that effort without making another struggle out of it? We let the breath finish and allow the next breath to be as it is. If disappointment appears, we recognize that too. We do not need to scold ourselves for having wanted a pleasant feeling.

In this way, seeing change supports letting go. An experience fades and ceases; repeatedly seeing this helps loosen our insistence that it remain. Relinquishment includes releasing that insistence. We can know the breath and its feeling without trying to own them. These contemplations belong together, but we need not divide every breath into four separate exercises.

During the sitting, keep your attention on what is actually happening. Later, we can reflect on what we noticed. Did wanting preserve the pleasant breath? What happened when we stopped demanding another one like it? Such reflection helps us understand the experience. Then, when we sit again, we return to observing. We give the teaching a chance to become clear through practice.⁸⁴

After meditation, we can bring this same understanding into daily life. What we observe in the breath—arising, changing, and passing away—we can also recognize in our feelings and thoughts. Suppose someone praises us and a pleasant feeling arises. Notice how that feeling changes. Can we enjoy it without trying to hold on to it? If someone speaks harshly and irritation arises, observe that too. The irritation does not remain exactly the same. It changes as the conditions supporting it change.

A thought about tomorrow may arise, occupy the mind, and then give way to another thought. We can notice its arising and passing without following every thought that appears. In this way, impermanence becomes something we recognize in our own experience. As our understanding deepens, we learn to let pleasant experiences pass without clinging and to meet unpleasant experiences without adding resistance. This is how we continue practicing beyond the meditation sitting.

⁸⁴ Gunaratana, *The Four Foundations of Mindfulness in Plain English*, chap. 1, “Breath and the Aggregates,” 23–24.

Chapter 7

Seeing Arising and Passing Away



The discourse says, “Seeing impermanence, I breathe in. Seeing impermanence, I breathe out.” What is impermanent? Form is impermanent.

“Contemplating impermanence in materiality, I shall breathe in.” In the discourse itself we do not see the word “materiality.” It simply says, “Seeing impermanence, I breathe in. Seeing impermanence, I breathe out.” When you say “seeing impermanence,” something must be impermanent. What is that something? It is nothing but the five aggregates.

Some people use the word “form,” but “materiality” is a better translation. Materiality means something composed of the four elements: earth, water, air, and fire. The word “form” does not express that meaning.

When we breathe in, we see materiality in the breath. “Contemplating impermanence in that materiality, I shall breathe in. Contemplating impermanence in materiality, I shall breathe out.”

Then we contemplate feeling: “Contemplating impermanence in feeling, I shall breathe in. Contemplating impermanence in feeling, I shall breathe out.” Feeling is not mentioned in the discourse either. It simply says, “Seeing impermanence, I breathe in. Seeing impermanence, I breathe out.” There is feeling when you breathe. We feel the breath, and that feeling is impermanent. Seeing that impermanence, I breathe in; seeing that impermanence, I breathe out.

The same applies to perception. Mentally, we perceive the breath. While perceiving it, we contemplate: “Contemplating impermanence in perception, I shall breathe in. Contemplating impermanence in perception, I shall breathe out.”

Next come volitional formations—that is, thoughts. We use the word “volitional” to distinguish these formations from “form,” the first aggregate. “Contemplating impermanence in volitional formations, I shall breathe in. Contemplating impermanence in volitional formations, I shall breathe out.”

The same applies to consciousness: “Contemplating impermanence in consciousness, I shall breathe in. Contemplating impermanence in consciousness, I shall breathe out.” These words make explicit what we include in our meditation practice: the impermanence of all five aggregates.

“I shall breathe in contemplating fading away.” What is fading away? The five aggregates are fading away. What is ceasing? The five aggregates are ceasing. What is relinquished? The five aggregates are relinquished.

When we practice mindfulness meditation, we become aware of impermanence as soon as we begin paying attention to the breath. As the breath rises and falls, so do feeling, perception, volitional thought, and consciousness. All five aggregates rise and fall.

The breath is form. We feel the breath; that is feeling. Mentally we perceive the breath; that is perception. We pay attention: intention and attention are volitional formations. We must be conscious to do all these things. These are called the five aggregates. They all rise and fall continually as we breathe in and out.

An impartial attitude helps us recognize these changes. The body may feel comfortable for a time and then become uncomfortable. A wholesome intention may be followed by impatience or doubt. We can recognize the feeling and the thought without treating either as the measure of the whole meditation.

Suppose you notice the touch of an in-breath at the nose. The breath and its bodily qualities belong to form. Its pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral tone is feeling. Recognizing the experience is perception. The intention to remain attentive belongs to volitional formations. Consciousness is the knowing of the experience. These distinctions help us understand what we call “my breathing.” They do not require us to find five little things sitting separately inside the breath.

Stay with that ordinary experience for a moment. Perhaps the touch is quite clear, and you recognize that the breath is coming in. Then a thought appears about something you have to do later. You notice that attention has wandered and intend to return. Nothing here requires an unusual meditation experience. You have noticed a bodily event, recognized it, become occupied with a thought, and renewed your intention. Look

carefully at these familiar changes. Which part were you calling “the same experience” when so much was changing?

At another moment, feeling may be clearer than thought. Begin with what is clear. We can distinguish a pleasant feeling from the wish to continue it. We can also distinguish recognizing the breath from intending to attend to it. The knowing also changes with the experience. Look for these differences in your own sitting.

Be patient with this examination. Trying to check off all five names with every breath can become another distraction. Let the breath steady the mind, and notice the aspects that become evident. When attention shifts, recognize the shift. We are learning to see the changing experience more clearly, without liking one part so much that we overlook the rest.⁸⁵

Concentration and mindfulness are like the two sides of a coin. In our practice they develop together.

When we gain concentration, we can see things exactly as they are. “Things” means the five aggregates. “Exactly as they are” means exactly as they are changing. When we see the five aggregates as they are, always changing, we understand that there is no permanent self.

When we begin to develop mindfulness by observing the breath, the arising and passing of vibrations, or the rise and fall of the abdomen, we see that nothing stays the same. Recognizing these continual changes also helps us understand selflessness, or no self.

⁸⁵ Gunaratana, *Meditation on Perception*, chap. 1, “Perception and the Aggregates” and “*Meditation on Perception* and the Aggregates,” 15–19.

One approach emphasizes calm and concentration; the other emphasizes insight. In *samatha*, the development of calm, we keep our attention on a meditation object, such as the breath. As distractions subside, the mind becomes steady, collected, and peaceful.

In *vipassanā*, the development of insight, we observe the body and mind to understand their nature. We see that sensations, feelings, and thoughts arise and pass away. They cannot provide lasting satisfaction, and we cannot regard them as “I” or “mine.” Through observing these characteristics directly, we learn to loosen our attachment.

These two approaches support one another. A settled mind helps us see clearly, and clear understanding helps us let go. Mindfulness supports both practices.⁸⁶

Concentration meditation leads to mindfulness, insight, and wisdom. Together, these help us recognize the changing nature of the five aggregates and understand that there is no permanent self.

The five aggregates arise and pass away together, very rapidly. They do not take turns, saying, “You change first, and then I change.” Nor do they change in sequence, like dominoes falling one after another. The mind must be very powerful to notice these rapid changes in form, feeling, perception, thought, and consciousness.

Sometimes changes in feeling are easier to notice than changes in the other aggregates. We can shift our awareness from one to another. When the mind is focused on the body, we can see bodily changes; when it is focused on feeling, we can see

⁸⁶ Gunaratana, *The Jhanas in Theravada Buddhist Meditation*, chap. 1, “The Doctrinal Context of Jhana” and “Jhana and Samadhi”; chap. 5, “The Way of Wisdom.”

changes in feeling. But we cannot slow these changes down or speed them up. The aggregates change at their own speed.

What Concentration Makes Possible

The Buddha distinguished several purposes for developing concentration. One is living happily here and now, through the four jhānas. Another is knowledge and vision, developed through attention to light and a mind kept open and luminous. A third is mindfulness with clear comprehension. A fourth is the ending of the taints—the mental corruptions that keep suffering going.⁸⁷

For mindfulness and clear comprehension, the emphasis is on knowing the course of an experience. A feeling arises and is known. Its presence is known, and its disappearance is known. We do the same with perceptions and thoughts. We are not concerned only with whether a particular feeling is agreeable. Attention stays with what is happening to it.

For the ending of the taints, the discourse directs attention to the five aggregates subject to clinging. Material form is understood, together with its arising and disappearance. Feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are examined in the same way. We investigate the aggregates in detail for a clear purpose: to be released from the corruptions that keep suffering going.

We can appreciate a peaceful sitting while also learning to understand the changing feelings and thoughts that occur within it. These benefits need not be confused with the

⁸⁷ AN 4.41.

completion of the path. The four purposes are not four consecutive levels of attainment. They help us understand what concentration makes possible and why we develop it.⁸⁸

Conditions of Arising and Cessation

When we examine impermanence, how many characteristics can we see in the arising and passing of the five aggregates? We can see twenty-five in arising and twenty-five in passing—fifty altogether.

This may be confusing if these terms are unfamiliar, so let me explain further.

First understand what we are counting. We examine each aggregate through five characteristics of arising and five of falling. That gives ten for each aggregate, or fifty for all five. Keeping this pattern in mind will help us follow the detailed explanation.

The twelve links of dependent origination offer a related way of examining how things depend on conditions. They trace the arising of suffering from ignorance and its cessation when the supporting conditions cease. Here we are counting ways of examining the five aggregates. We should keep these two arrangements clear as we study them.

Do not be discouraged by the number. We can begin with materiality and understand how its five characteristics are counted. Then we can follow the same pattern for feeling. We already have some familiarity with the changing breath and changing feelings. This explanation helps us examine their conditions more carefully while staying in touch with our experience.⁸⁹

⁸⁸ AN 4.41.

⁸⁹ For the fifty characteristics, see Ñāṇamoli, trans., *The Path of Discrimination* (Paṭisambhidāmagga), treatise I, chap. VI, “Rise and Fall,” §§285–294, 66–70; also Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, XX.97–99.

Let us take our own bodies as an example. What we call materiality includes the four great elements—earth, water, fire, and air—and the physical qualities that depend on them. Our bodies belong to this aggregate.

How does this materiality arise? We can look at this in two ways. We can understand the conditions that bring it about, and we can observe its arising. Here, we consider four conditions: ignorance, craving, kamma, and nutriment. Kamma means intentional action; nutriment means nourishment.

When we do not understand things as they are, including the four noble truths, ignorance remains. We continue to crave and cling, sustaining becoming, the renewal of existence. Our intentional actions can bear fruit in a future existence. Past kamma thus conditions the arising of a new physical body. Such kamma includes mental, physical, and verbal actions performed in this life or in previous lives. When we speak of ignorance, craving, and kamma as conditions for materiality, we are looking at how bodily existence continues through the cycle of rebirth.

The first three conditions are subtle, but nutriment is easier to recognize. We eat, and the food nourishes the body, sustaining it and supporting the continued arising of its material processes. Without this nourishment, the body cannot maintain itself.⁹⁰

Then we look at the arising itself. A physical phenomenon comes into being, and we recognize that arising. This is what is meant by seeing the characteristic of arising. It is the fifth aspect of this contemplation. The first four concern the conditions that support materiality; the fifth concerns seeing its actual arising. We come to understand that this body depends on conditions and that its material processes continually arise and pass

⁹⁰ Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, XIX.4, 13; XX.97–99.

away. This is seeing with wisdom—with the mental eye, not the physical eyes. With our physical eyes we see material things within the body and outside it; wisdom enables us to discern their arising.

As something changes, we can see three phases: it arises, reaches a peak, and passes away. These are its beginning, middle, and end. This applies to every aggregate.

We can now look more closely at the role of *saṅkhāra*. In its broadest sense, *saṅkhāra* means something that has arisen from causes and conditions. What is conditioned also helps condition what follows. In dependent origination, we are concerned particularly with volitional formations: the intentions expressed through thought, speech, and bodily action. Under the influence of ignorance, these intentions keep conditioning our experience and supporting renewed existence. Ignorance gives rise to materiality through this process of conditioning, rather than by producing a body on its own.

Ignorance has no beginning in the past. The phrase “With the arising of ignorance” should not be taken to mean that there was once no ignorance and that materiality first appeared at the moment ignorance began. That assumption is mistaken; it, too, is based on ignorance.

Nor should we assume that only wisdom existed before ignorance appeared. We must also understand how this conditioning operates now. Ignorance influences our present intentions, and those intentions condition the body and mind we experience, just as earlier intentions have conditioned our present experience. What we think, say, and do

now also helps shape what follows. In this way, ignorance continues to sustain material existence; we are not speaking only of something that happened in the distant past.⁹¹

When ignorance arises, we act under its influence without recognizing the danger.

What we fail to understand is the nature of materiality. It is subject to old age and afflictions, and no one has absolute control over it. Under the influence of ignorance, we keep supporting it in various ways.

Craving also nourishes the root of materiality. We seek satisfaction through the objects of the eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind. Desire also lies behind our pursuit of food and drink, through which we nourish the body and sustain its existence. As long as we feed craving, we feed materiality.

The four kinds of nutriment are material food, contact, mental volition (intentional activity), and consciousness. As long as we bring in these nutriments through our craving, our kamma, and our ignorance, we cause materiality to arise.

We also contemplate the characteristic of birth: the coming together of the aggregates and the six sense bases—eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind. One who sees this characteristic sees the arising of materiality.⁹²

Khandha means an aggregate—a collection or group. One group is called form; another is called feeling. The feeling aggregate includes different kinds of feeling: those arising from eye contact, ear contact, nose contact, tongue contact, body contact, and mind contact.

⁹¹ Gunaratana and Ziegler, *Dependent Origination in Plain English*, chap. 2, “Volitional Formations.”

⁹² SN 12.11, on the four nutriments; SN 12.2, definition of birth.

Materiality, the physical aspect of our experience, depends on conditions. When the conditions of ignorance, craving, kamma, and nutriment cease, the materiality dependent on them is no longer produced.

We need to understand this carefully. When ignorance and craving are completely uprooted through full understanding of the four noble truths, the conditions for kamma to produce another birth are cut off. This does not mean that the present body disappears. It continues until the end of that life. Nutriment, or physical nourishment, supports the body during life; the physical processes dependent on that nourishment cannot continue without it.⁹³

Alongside understanding these conditions, we observe materiality itself arising and passing away. This is the fifth aspect of the contemplation. We see that what has arisen comes to an end. This is what is meant by seeing the “fall of materiality.”

We therefore have five aspects of arising and five of cessation, making ten altogether. Four on each side concern conditions; the fifth concerns arising or passing away itself. Applying the same method to feeling, perception, mental formations, and consciousness gives fifty aspects altogether. The conditions differ: contact takes the place of nutriment for feeling, perception, and mental formations; mentality and materiality take its place for consciousness.⁹⁴

Consider feeling, or *vedanā*. Contact is the nutriment that supports it: feeling arises dependent on contact and ceases when that contact ceases. We also observe feeling itself

⁹³ On the liberated person’s remaining faculties during life, see Itivuttaka 44. For conditional and momentary cessation, see Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, XX.97–100.

⁹⁴ Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, XX.97–100, citing Paṭisambhidāmagga I.55–57; Ñāṇamoli, trans., *The Path of Discrimination*, treatise I, chap. VI, §§285–294, 66–70.

arising and passing away. Understanding its conditions and seeing these changes with wisdom are distinct aspects of the same contemplation.

The Sense Bases and Contact

When we look very closely at each thing in the following groups, we see the same process taking place. For each of the six internal sense bases and each of the six external sense bases—the objects of those senses—we examine the ten aspects of arising and passing away described earlier.

Let me elaborate a little on each of them. The six internal sense bases are eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind. The external sense bases are form, sound, smell, taste, touch, and mind objects. The six kinds of consciousness are eye consciousness, ear consciousness, nose consciousness, tongue consciousness, body consciousness, and mind consciousness.

There are also six kinds of contact, or sense impressions, corresponding to the six senses. The six kinds of feeling arise from eye contact, ear contact, nose contact, tongue contact, body contact, and mind contact. Then there are six kinds of perception: perception of form, sound, smell, taste, touch, and dhamma—mind objects.

Then there are six kinds of volition: thought of form, thought of sound, thought of smell, thought of taste, thought of touch, and thought of mind objects. There are six kinds of craving: craving for form, sound, smell, taste, touch, and mind objects.

There are six kinds of applied thought, concerning form, sound, and the other sense objects. There are also six kinds of sustained thought, or vicāra, concerning those same objects. We should examine each through the ten aspects of arising and passing away described earlier.

Eye consciousness arises dependent on the eyes and visual objects. This is what we mean here by arising.

When you hear a sound, ear consciousness arises dependent on the sound and the ear. We refer to this metaphorically as the arising of the ear faculty. Nose consciousness arises when the nose and a smell come together. Tongue consciousness arises when you put something into your mouth—food, water, and so forth. At that moment, you become aware of the experience.

When we touch something tangible, the body and that object come together, and body consciousness arises. When we remember something, mind and mind objects come together, and mind consciousness arises. In this way, we become aware of the arising of the six internal sense bases: eyes, ears, nose, tongue, body, and mind.

We need focused attention, mindfulness, and concentration to recognize this arising of the six senses.

Now consider the external sense bases. As soon as we open our eyes, visual objects appear to us. We speak of this as the arising of the external sense base. Similarly, when we attend to a sound and hear it, we speak of the external sense base of sound arising.

The same applies to all six external sense bases. As any object—visual, auditory, and so forth—strikes a sense base, our awareness goes straight to it. In the Dhamma, we call this becoming aware of the arising of an external object, or external sense base.

Attention is necessary for us to recognize this arising.

Here we are speaking about the object becoming known in our experience. We are not saying that attention brings a physical object into existence. Something may already

be present without our noticing it. Our concern in this practice is how an object becomes known, and what happens with that knowing.

Suppose you are sitting with the breath and hear a sound outside. With the ear, the sound, and auditory consciousness, there is contact. The sound may be felt as unpleasant and recognized as someone talking. Very quickly, the mind can begin complaining. We can distinguish these aspects when we examine the experience, although during the sitting they occur too closely together to seem like a procession of separate events.

Perhaps you begin wondering who is speaking and why they cannot be quiet. You rehearse what you would say to them. By then, you may be attending more to your own complaint than to the sound. The sound changes, but the argument continues. Notice the extra work the mind is doing. It keeps carrying the argument after the immediate experience has passed.

Now consider another possibility. You recognize the unpleasant feeling and the wish for silence. You notice that the sound varies and that your irritation varies too. There is no need to turn the irritation into a judgment about yourself or the speaker. Let the reaction settle, and return to the breath. You have not made the sound disappear by withdrawing attention. You have stopped adding to the quarrel in the mind. This is a practical way to investigate the two directions we will discuss: feeding the reaction, or understanding it and letting go.⁹⁵

Consciousness arises dependent on a sense faculty and its object. The coming together of these three is called contact. This is a changing process: each instance arises

⁹⁵ Gunaratana, *Meditation on Perception*, chap. 1, discussion of sense contact, 11–13.

and passes away, followed by another. With mindfulness, we can observe this continual arising and passing away.⁹⁶

If you focus on the external sense base alone, you do not see its impermanence. If you attend only to the internal sense base, you do not see impermanence there. You must see the two come together and consciousness arise. Your consciousness must be present for you to recognize impermanence when a sense base and its object come together.

Contact, feeling, perception, volition, consciousness, and attention are all involved in the experience. When an object, such as a material form, meets a sense faculty, these arise together. We cannot isolate any one of them from the whole process; they work together.

Attention is essential if we are to recognize these changes. If the mind is elsewhere, we miss the arising and passing of contact, even though a sense faculty, its object, and consciousness have come together. With mindfulness, we can know the changing nature of the internal and external sense bases, consciousness, and contact. In this sense, all dhammas, or phenomena, become known to us through attention.⁹⁷

Here we can see both how suffering develops and how it can be brought to an end. If we follow the feelings and perceptions that arise with contact without recognizing their impermanence, greed, hatred, and delusion can continue. The mind carries on reacting, just as it keeps arguing after the sound outside has passed.

With mindfulness, we notice that contact changes and that feeling and perception change with it. We see these experiences arise, continue for a time, and cease. As their

⁹⁶ MN 148, Chachakka Sutta, the explanations of the six classes of consciousness and contact.

⁹⁷ Compare AN 10.58.

impermanence becomes clear, we learn not to hold on to what is passing away. We allow it to cease and let it go. In this way, we begin to free the mind from suffering.

These are the two streams: one carries suffering forward; the other leads toward liberation. Mindfulness allows us to recognize which direction the mind is taking and to cultivate the understanding that brings peace. We need that awareness to find our way out of the thicket of suffering.

The Wider Field

We must apply the same understanding to every item in these groups. There are thousands of ways to observe arising and passing.

There are six elements: earth, water, fire, air, space, and consciousness. The sixth, consciousness, is the knowing of experience. The body is also divided into thirty-two parts for contemplation, including hair, skin, bones, and internal organs. Then there are the twelve internal and external sense bases: the six internal bases and their respective objects.

There are also eighteen elements: the eye element, visible-form element, and eye-consciousness element; the ear element, sound element, and ear-consciousness element; nose element, smell element, and nose-consciousness element; tongue element, taste element, and tongue-consciousness element; body element, tangible element, and body-consciousness element; mind element, mind-object element, and mind-consciousness element.

There are nine kinds of existence, arranged in three groups of three: sensual, fine-material, and immaterial; percipient, nonpercipient, and neither-percipient-nor-nonpercipient; and one-constituent, four-constituent, and five-constituent. People

generally do not know these classifications unless they have studied that particular section of the Dhamma.

Sensual becoming, also called sense-desire becoming, means existence in which one can experience things through the six senses. One becomes a being in one of several worlds: the human world, animal world, divine world, and so forth.

Then there is fine-material becoming, or existence in a subtle material form. You meditate and attain the jhānas: first, second, third, and fourth jhāna. Then you die with the jhānic experience and are reborn in realms where your meditative state continues.

The four immaterial attainments, also called peaceful liberations, bring peace and happiness through temporary liberation of the mind from the hindrances. They are the perception of infinite space, the perception of infinite consciousness, the perception of nothingness, and neither perception nor nonperception. These attainments are reached only through meditation. Immaterial becoming refers to existence without material form, corresponding to these attainments.

Percipient becoming means existence with perception. Nonpercipient becoming has materiality but no mental aggregates. In neither-percipient-nor-nonpercipient becoming, perception is so subtle that it is described as neither present nor absent. Finally, becoming may be described according to the aggregates present. One-constituent becoming consists of materiality alone; four-constituent becoming consists of the four mental aggregates; and five-constituent becoming includes all five aggregates.⁹⁸

The four mind-deliverances are loving-friendliness, compassion, appreciative joy, and equanimity. They are also called *brahmavihāras*. The word *brahma* refers to what is

⁹⁸ Buddhaghosa, *The Path of Purification*, XVII.253–255, 264.

highest, noblest, or purest, while *vihāra* means a way of living or abiding. Through diligent and repeated practice, these qualities become our way of living, bringing purity and nobility into our lives.

They are called mind-deliverances because, while we dwell in them, the mind is temporarily freed from greed, hatred, and delusion.

Suppose someone you know has been offered a position that you also wanted. You know how much effort this person has made and how happy the family will be. You can appreciate that happiness. Yet the mind may immediately turn to your own disappointment: Why was I not chosen? Why does this person have something I do not have? Instead of sharing in the happiness, you begin measuring one life against another.

Notice where your attention has gone. The other person has received good news, but now you are occupied with what it means about you. You may even begin looking for faults in the person or reasons why the success is undeserved. Recognizing this reaction gives you something to work with. You can stop feeding the comparison and give attention to the happiness in front of you.

Perhaps this position will allow the person to support a family or do work for which they have prepared for years. Listen when they tell you about it. Let yourself appreciate what has gone well for them. You can offer sincere congratulations without turning the conversation back to your own circumstances. Another person's success need not become a reason for resentment.

This is appreciative joy. We often find it easy to be glad when someone dear to us does well. We can cultivate that same willingness to rejoice when another person's circumstances are better than our own. If jealousy is present, recognize it honestly.

Pretending to be pleased while nourishing resentment does not help us understand the mind.

We do not have to receive the same good fortune before we can appreciate it in someone else's life. Their happiness gives us an opportunity to cultivate a wholesome response. In this way, the practice extends beyond the people whose success we already find easy to welcome.⁹⁹

As the practice deepens, these wholesome states themselves can become objects of insight. We recognize that they arise through conditions and are subject to change and cessation. Understanding them in this way, we can use them as a basis for liberation from saṃsāric suffering—the suffering of repeated birth and death.

When we practice mettā, we extend loving-friendliness to beings everywhere, without restriction. Our concern includes their suffering as well as our own. But how deeply do we understand suffering? We readily recognize obvious pain and distress. Through practice, we begin to see more clearly how suffering arises through attachment to what is changing. Our wish for beings to be free from suffering leads us to investigate its causes and the way to its ending.

This is where dependent origination becomes directly relevant. It explains how suffering arises in dependence on conditions and how it ceases when those conditions cease. Its twelve links are ignorance, volitional formations, consciousness, mentality and materiality (mental and physical factors), the six sense bases, contact, feeling, craving,

⁹⁹ Gunaratana, *Mindfulness in Plain English*, 20th anniversary ed. (2011), afterword, “The Power of Loving Friendliness,” “The Four Sublime States,” 174–75.

clinging, becoming, birth, and aging and death. Together, they describe the conditions that sustain the round of existence and its suffering.¹⁰⁰

Merely remembering these names is not enough. We must investigate what they mean in our own experience. As with our examination of the fifty characteristics, we look carefully at the conditions for arising and cessation. We bring this investigation to each link, observing its dependence on conditions and its changing nature.

Let us begin with something familiar: feeling. When a sense faculty, its object, and the corresponding consciousness come together, there is contact. Dependent on contact, feeling arises. That feeling may be pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Without clear understanding, we tend to grasp at what is pleasant and resist what is unpleasant. Neutral feeling often passes unnoticed. Craving develops when we want an experience to continue, want it to disappear, or want something else to take its place. As craving strengthens, we cling. This clinging sustains becoming and the continuation of suffering.

We can observe this while meditating. A pleasant feeling arises, and we want to keep it. An uncomfortable feeling arises, and we become impatient with it. What happens if we attend carefully to the feeling itself? We see that it changes. We also notice the desire to hold on or push away. With mindfulness and understanding, we can experience the feeling without feeding these reactions. The feeling is known, and its impermanence is known.

In this way, we begin to understand both the arising of suffering and the possibility of its cessation. A moment of letting go shows us the value of the practice. Complete liberation requires the full development of the path and the ending of ignorance and

¹⁰⁰ SN 12.2.

craving. The noble eightfold path provides the training through which this understanding matures.

Mindfulness of breathing supports this training by developing the qualities the mind needs to see clearly. It serves the same purpose as our investigation of dependent origination: understanding suffering so thoroughly that its causes can be abandoned.

From Breathing to Awakening

As we become familiar with breathing, we also learn about the body, feelings, mind, and the changing phenomena we experience. The four foundations of mindfulness develop through this practice. We remain attentive and clearly aware, letting go of the craving and distress that interfere with seeing. From these foundations grow seven qualities that support awakening. The *Ānāpānasati Sutta* explains how they develop together.¹⁰¹

First, mindfulness becomes established. We stay with what is happening instead of continually losing touch with it. When the body is the subject of contemplation, we remain aware of the body. That mindfulness makes it possible to look more carefully. We begin to investigate the experience with wisdom.

This is the awakening factor of investigation. Mindfulness keeps us in touch with the experience so that we can examine it with wisdom. Does a feeling remain the same? What conditions support it? What happens when those conditions change? We look carefully, understand the experience more clearly, and learn from it.

As we investigate, energy arises. As understanding grows, we recognize the value of the practice and become encouraged to continue. We bring renewed energy to it. The mind is engaged in understanding rather than sinking or becoming slack. This is the

¹⁰¹ MN 118, §§24–40.

awakening factor of energy. Our effort is directed toward understanding through careful observation.

With energy comes joy that does not depend on sensual pleasure. As understanding grows and the mind's burden eases, the practice itself uplifts us. We need not approach it as an unbroken struggle. This joy, too, supports awakening.

As joy develops, body and mind become tranquil. The body settles, and the mind settles. There is ease. With that ease and happiness, the mind becomes concentrated and can remain clearly and steadily with its object. Tranquility and concentration are closely connected: a mind at ease can become collected and remain steady.

We then regard the concentrated mind with equanimity, without grasping at its peacefulness or becoming disturbed by change. There is no need to disturb its steadiness by reaching for something else or trying to possess the experience. We know the collected mind with a steady, even awareness. Equanimity is the seventh awakening factor, following mindfulness, investigation, energy, joy, tranquility, and concentration.¹⁰²

These qualities can grow while we contemplate feelings, the mind, or phenomena as well as the body. The subject of contemplation can change while the awakening factors continue to develop.¹⁰³

What We Nourish

What we repeatedly attend to affects the mind. Desire can grow as we dwell on an attractive feature. Ill will can grow as we return again and again to what offends us.

¹⁰² MN 118, §§30–36.

¹⁰³ MN 118, §§37–40.

Mental unrest feeds restlessness and remorse. Doubt, too, grows when we attend unwisely to the conditions that support it. Sluggishness is fed by conditions such as weariness, yawning, heaviness after eating, and a sinking mind. The Nutriment Sutta asks us to understand how these states are fed.¹⁰⁴

Suppose we recognize anger but continue dwelling on what offends us. Recognition has occurred, yet the anger is still being nourished. Loving-friendliness offers a different support for the mind. When we attend wisely to the freedom found in loving-friendliness, ill will is deprived of nourishment.

Different hindrances call for different responses. Attention to the unattractive aspect counters sensual desire. The willingness to begin making an effort, persist, and exert ourselves counters sluggishness. Quieting the mind counters restlessness and remorse. Discernment of wholesome and unwholesome qualities, of what is blameworthy and blameless, counters doubt. We learn what is needed to address the present difficulty.

The awakening factors also need nourishment. Investigation grows through wise attention to the distinction between harmful and beneficial qualities. Energy grows when we attend to our ability to begin an effort and keep it going. Tranquility is supported by calming body and mind. Calm and freedom from distraction support concentration. Mindfulness, joy, and equanimity also grow when we attend to the conditions that support them.

If we repeatedly neglect those supports, we do not sustain the beneficial qualities. Something wholesome may have appeared in a sitting, but it still needs cultivation. We

¹⁰⁴ SN 46.51.

can learn both to stop feeding an obstacle and to nourish the qualities that help us see clearly.¹⁰⁵

Tending the Fire

Imagine a small fire that you want to build up. You add wet grass, wet dung, and wet wood, sprinkle it with water, and cover it with dust. Will it grow? Those actions weaken the fire. Adding dry fuel and blowing on it would help it burn.

Now imagine a large fire that you want to extinguish. Adding dry grass and wood and blowing on it would make your work harder. Wet fuel, water, and a covering of dust would help put it out. The Buddha used these two situations to explain how to work with a sluggish mind and an agitated mind.¹⁰⁶

When the mind has become sluggish, it is time to develop investigation, energy, and joy. They help lift it. Emphasizing tranquility, concentration, and equanimity at that moment does not readily lift the mind from dullness. It is like putting wet fuel on the small fire you want to strengthen.

When the mind is excited, tranquility, concentration, and equanimity help it settle. Further stimulation through investigation, energy, and joy would make calming it difficult. It would be like feeding the large fire you want to extinguish.

We need to know which condition is present. A sluggish mind and a balanced mind may both appear quiet, yet we need to recognize the difference. A dull mind needs to be enlivened; an agitated mind needs to be calmed. This is why mindfulness remains useful

¹⁰⁵ SN 46.51.

¹⁰⁶ SN 46.53.

throughout. With mindfulness we recognize the mind's condition and remain aware as it changes. We learn when to encourage energy and when to encourage calm.¹⁰⁷

Knowledge and Freedom

All seven awakening factors are developed toward release. Each rests on seclusion, dispassion—the fading of passion—and cessation; each matures toward relinquishment. This applies to energy and joy just as much as to tranquility, concentration, and equanimity. As attachment fades and understanding becomes clear, these factors mature toward true knowledge and liberation.¹⁰⁸

We may enjoy a collected mind, but we need not hold on to it as a possession. We may experience joy, but we need not demand that it stay. These qualities serve the loosening and ending of attachment. Letting go gives direction to their cultivation, just as it does in the final breathing instructions.

The fulfillment described by the Buddha is knowledge and freedom. We carry out this work through repeated practice: knowing what is present, understanding it, nourishing the qualities that support awakening, and learning to relinquish. We return to the breath with that purpose.¹⁰⁹

¹⁰⁷ SN 46.53.

¹⁰⁸ MN 118, §§41–43.

¹⁰⁹ MN 118, §§28–43.

Chapter 8

Questions from Practice



Settling into Practice

Is it all right to focus on tension in the body before turning to the breath? There is a great deal of tension, and settling it can take a long time. Can I begin by paying attention to the tension and then move to the breath?

I think so. When the tension is so strong that you cannot attend to the breath, it is better to pay attention to the tension first and let it settle. Once you feel comfortable and can feel the breath more easily, turn your attention to breathing.

When I focus on the breath, I feel very calm. Then I have a sense of being in a natural setting, usually beside a river or in a forest. The same scene appears from one meditation to the next. Should I let this image go, or try to go more deeply into the experience?

These images can become distractions. We have seen so many things in our lives, and we have heard, smelled, tasted, and touched so many things. They are all in our memory bank. When we meditate, some of them come to the surface. The scene beside a river is something we are imagining. Let it go and stay with the subject of meditation. In this case, the subject is the breath.

Training the mind is like training a wild calf. The mind is so accustomed to wandering that it does not like to stay with one object. It struggles like a fish out of water, always trying to find something to hold on to. We are training it to stay with one object: the breath.

Venerable, is it all right to count the breaths up to ten and then count backward?

Yes. Counting is recommended as a way to keep the mind focused on the breath. There are several ways to do it. One is to count quickly up to five or ten. Another is called the farmer's counting.

A farmer measuring grain uses a container to transfer it from one bag to another. As he carries the first measure to the other bag, he repeats, "One, one, one," until he empties it. With the next measure, he repeats, "Two, two, two." This keeps him from losing track of how much grain he has measured. He keeps the count in his mind by repeating each number.

Similarly, as you breathe in until the lungs are full, repeat, “One, one, one.” Continue repeating “one” as you breathe out. With the second breath, repeat “two” in the same way, and continue up to five. This keeps the mind engaged with the counting.

A third method is to count from one to ten and then backward to one. The next time, count from one to nine and back; then from one to eight and back, and so on. Even while counting, the mind may wander. You may remember reaching seven but no longer know whether the next number should be eight or six. When that happens, begin again at one.

Keep the counting connected to the breath. Its purpose is to help you attend to breathing. If you go beyond ten, you may become so occupied with the numbers that you forget the breath. By keeping the count within these limits, you can eventually let go of counting while the mind remains with the breath. So yes, counting up to ten and back is all right.

Understanding Unfamiliar Experiences

Is there a state in meditation in which there is no awareness and afterward no memory of what happened, but which is not sleep? During sitting meditation, I sometimes have periods that seem like blackouts. I have no awareness of what is happening and no memory of it afterward, although I feel very relaxed when I come out of them.

You do not remember what happened because you were sleeping. When you sleep, you are not aware of what is happening during the meditation. If you are awake, you remember what passes through the mind.

Meditation does not mean blocking the mind's activities. You see things arising and passing away, appearing and disappearing. You see impermanence, first at a gross level and then at increasingly subtle levels. When you are aware of these changes, you cannot say that you remember nothing.

Sometimes during meditation, the body sways slowly forward and backward or from side to side. Is this caused by the movement of awareness, or by rapture? What causes these movements?

As you breathe in and out, the movement of the breath can move the body. You fall into a rhythm, and the body follows that rhythm. This is better than falling asleep and repeatedly nodding forward and backward!

When the body moves from side to side like a pendulum as you breathe, the movement is involuntary. You do not have to be concerned about it. It does not mean that you lack concentration; the body is simply moving with the breath without your consciously directing it.

Sometimes, when I become very quiet in meditation, I seem to feel the skin breathing along with the lungs, as though I were breathing through the skin. Is this imagination, or is it a useful perception? How can I make use of it?

I am not sure what you mean by this. But when we meditate, we want to develop awareness of the impermanence of everything. We contemplate the impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and selflessness of the thirty-two parts of the body. Most of these parts are inside, where we cannot see them. Outwardly, we can see head hair, body hair, nails, teeth, and skin. Over time, we can see them change. These outward changes begin within the body.

We can imagine or visualize the inner parts: flesh, bones, bone marrow, kidneys, liver, diaphragm, heart, lungs, and so forth. We live because these parts are functioning, and functioning means changing. They are not static. We have to understand this and picture them as continually changing.

There is a simile in Buddhist literature of a glass bowl. Looking at it from outside, you can see what is inside. In the same way, the inner parts of the body can become very clear to the mind. Another version of the simile uses a crystal ball. You hold it in your palm and look at it in bright light. With good eyesight, you can see what is inside.

I sometimes hesitate to use the word “visualize,” because people may think of imagining UFOs or traveling through space to the moon. That is not what I mean. We are considering what is within our own bodies, picturing these parts vibrating and changing all the time. This is something we can do.

It helps us understand the outward changes as well. Our hair turns gray because of changes within the body. Our skin wrinkles for the same reason. I cannot explain these changes scientifically or biologically, but we can understand that what we see on the surface has been developing inside. That is the kind of imagination we can use.

I described experiencing rising and falling as vibration, and you said I could take that vibration as an object of meditation. Previously, attending to vibration had confused me, but I tried again and had a different experience. When I let the vibration spread through the whole body, the mind seems to gain energy and wakefulness. It is calm without being dull. Sometimes it takes more than an hour to settle into this flow.

I experience more energy, tranquility, and equanimity, but I do not feel joy or happiness. I feel joy outside meditation, but not while meditating. I seem to prefer the calm of tranquility and equanimity. Could you comment on the absence of joy during meditation?

If you experience vibration, focus your mind on it. You can then see the body, feelings, breath, and thoughts united in the same rhythm. There is nothing to become excited or agitated about. The mind naturally becomes calm, relaxed, and peaceful. This leads to joy, happiness, and concentration.

When you experience the vibration, do not get excited or start thinking about it. Your difficulty seems to lie in thinking and anticipating what will happen next. Let go of that expectation. Relax, allow the vibration to continue, and pay attention to it.

I can give you some hints, but it is up to you to remain calm without expecting anything. As you let the experience unfold, you will notice that the breath becomes very smooth and the body and mind settle. Thoughts no longer arise, and joy, happiness, and concentration develop naturally.

That concentration could be a jhānic state. The second group of four instructions in mindfulness of breathing begins with experiencing pīti, or joy, and sukha, or happiness.

These arise naturally as you experience the first jhāna. Let this happen without becoming excited or agitated.

I followed your advice and now use vibration as my meditation object. For several years I practiced insight meditation, vipassanā, intensely and found it fruitful, but eventually it became less so. Working with vibration seems to lead me toward samatha, or calm, which feels appropriate now. Is it possible to experience the physical or fine-material signs of pīti without feeling joy? I do not want to become agitated. Pīti and these other perceptions do not seem very tranquil, and I would rather not react to them emotionally. Can you comment?

You are adding another factor to your practice: your emotional reaction. Set that reaction aside temporarily so that you can see what is happening. You experience vibration, which is a sign of arising and passing away—a sign of impermanence. There is no need to worry about it. Worry brings fear, tension, and anxiety.

This is a natural process. The difference is that now you are aware of it. At other times, vibration continues without your noticing it. When you become aware of it, you may feel afraid.

Your heart, for instance, beats all the time. If you keep listening to it, you may become frightened and try to put it out of your mind. But when you practice mindfulness of impermanence, you can become aware of the vibration of the heartbeat and remain calm, relaxed, and peaceful. In this way, you gain insight into impermanence.

You can also develop concentration. As the vibration repeats, the mind becomes familiar with its rhythm, stays with it, and settles down. Whether you develop

concentration or insight, you need the spiritual maturity to accept what is happening without reacting emotionally.

We are attached to all five aggregates: the body, feelings, perceptions, mental formations, and consciousness. When these experiences arise, let them happen. What you are describing is a natural process in body and mind, not a sickness. Of course, if there is a sickness, you have to attend to it. Here, as body and mind work together, you experience vibration. Accept it and stay with it. You can develop concentration or the wisdom to see impermanence, because everything is impermanent.

When sitting in meditation, I often feel waves entering the body, as if something from outside has come to visit. Could this happen because someone is thinking of me, or because devas, or heavenly beings, have come to visit?

No, we do not need to think that way. When we become calm and peaceful, we may experience vibration, light, or pīti. The second group of four instructions in the Ānāpānasati Sutta begins with experiencing gladness as we breathe in and out. Happiness then arises within our own mind as our meditation develops.

There is no need to imagine an external force entering the body. That is superstition. We have to let go of superstition and stay with this simple, natural experience.

Balance and Discernment

I perceive my body as an energy body, and I also feel waves of energy passing through it. Sometimes these are quite strong. The vibration feels friendly, calming, and soothing; at other times, it feels a little excited and very happy. I simply observe it. It does not affect my mood, and eventually the wave passes. Can you comment?

Energy is one of the five faculties, also called strengths or powers: faith or confidence, energy, mindfulness, concentration, and wisdom. You have to learn to balance them. If you focus on only one, the mind will not be very peaceful. When you balance them, the mind remains at peace.

For instance, as energy rises and falls, your mood may change with it. The same can happen when faith rises and falls. In meditation, we need to balance all five faculties.

Mindfulness helps us recognize which faculty is stronger than the others. To restore balance, we need to strengthen the quieter side of the practice. If energy is excessive, turn your attention to faith. In this way, you can maintain a peaceful state of mind.

I have been contemplating the unattractiveness of the body. When I practice loving-friendliness afterward, it feels dull and less effective. What would you suggest?

It should become more effective, because contemplation of the unattractiveness of the body is a very subtle practice through which you can develop equanimity. You can contemplate unattractiveness in what appears attractive, or attractiveness in what appears unattractive. Then you give up both and practice equanimity. This is a very high level of the practice.

Equanimity is one of the four brahmavihāras. When you begin to practice one, you also develop the other three. Whenever the Buddha mentioned mettā, he mentioned the other three as well. In practice, you select one and develop the others along with it.

You need to understand both contemplation of unattractiveness and mettā, and keep the two in balance. Both are effective forms of meditation. Contemplate the unattractiveness of the body carefully and mindfully, and practice mettā with the same care and mindfulness.

Sometimes I notice a gap between the in-breath and the out-breath, or between the out-breath and the next in-breath. There is a feeling of emptiness, and it feels peaceful. How should I understand this?

In the experience you describe, the feeling of emptiness comes from your own negative imagination. You say it feels peaceful, but that peacefulness is not the real peace that comes from seeing reality. When you see clearly that the mind is free from greed, hatred, and delusion, you experience real peace. Simply feeling empty and then peaceful is not an attainment.

Some people feel depressed because they have come to believe the harsh things others have said about them. As children, they may have heard their parents say, “You are good for nothing. You cannot do anything. You are always a failure.” Teachers or other people may have spoken to them in the same way. Taking these remarks to heart, they begin to think, “Yes, I am worth nothing.”

I remember a young man attending a university in America whose parents had come from another country. One day in class, someone joked, “Hey, your hands are short.”

From then on, he believed his hands were too short. He went home and blamed his parents. They could not convince him that there was nothing wrong with his hands.

His parents brought him to see me and asked me to help. I told him, “Your hands are not short. They are normal.”

“No, no,” he replied. “You are supporting my parents too.”

He came to see me several times, and each time I assured him that his hands were normal. Finally, he said, “I have a solution. I will ask a doctor to shorten my legs so that my legs and hands are the same length.”

I said, “Think about what you are suggesting. If you have your legs shortened, one day someone may say, ‘Your neck is long.’ What will you do then? Have your neck shortened?”

This is how an idea planted by someone else can take hold in the mind.

Most teachers speak of eight jhānas, but the Buddha speaks here of four jhānas and four āyatanas, or immaterial attainments. Why does he use different terms for the two groups? Does the distinction have a particular meaning?

People generally speak of eight jhānas. Four of these attainments are called peaceful liberations. They are the most peaceful of the mundane attainments, which do not in themselves amount to final liberation. At that level, there is no longer a struggle between the hindrances and the jhānic factors. The mind settles into a pure state of peace.

It is easy to call all eight “jhānas” or “attainments,” but the Buddha distinguished the four jhānas, described as living in happiness in this life, from the four peaceful liberations. Later teachers grouped the two together and called them eight jhānas. The Buddha did not use that expression.

In the West, especially where science is strongly emphasized, many people do not believe in supernatural powers. Why is disbelief in beings with such powers considered a harmful wrong view?

We do not know everything in the universe. We know a certain number of things, but that does not allow us to conclude with certainty, “This alone is right. Nothing else can be true.”

You yourself can attain supernatural powers. They are not necessary for enlightenment, but they exist. If you do not believe in them, you block the possibility of attaining them. This is why such disbelief is considered a wrong view: it obstructs that progress and attainment.

Mindfulness in Daily Life

Is it always possible to be mindful from moment to moment in everyday life?

I think this is possible when you attain full enlightenment. Until then, the mind has layers and layers of defilements that keep coming to the surface. They are stirred up by our encounters with people, our work, family life, studies, and the situations we face. So many things draw our attention away that we cannot maintain moment-to-moment mindfulness all the time.

During the time you dedicate to vipassanā meditation, however, moment-to-moment awareness is possible. An unenlightened person is called a puthujjana, one whose mind is continually invaded by unwholesome mental states. In ordinary daily life, such a person finds it extremely difficult to remain mindful from moment to moment.

I emphasize that during meditation, when you sit in one place and focus the mind on one object, you gain a degree of concentration. Then moment-to-moment awareness becomes possible. When you leave meditation, the mind is again flooded with sights, sounds, smells, tastes, touches, and thoughts.

Can practicing mindfulness of breathing regularly increase mindfulness? How can we become more mindful in daily life?

You have to practice mindfulness every day. Devote more time to meditation and sit more often.

In the Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, doesn't the Buddha say that mindfulness should be practiced at all times, from moment to moment?

Yes. We should practice mindfulness while sitting, standing, walking, lying down, eating, drinking, answering the call of nature, and so forth. If something interrupts our mindfulness during these activities, we return to it.

Practicing in this way, even with interruptions, builds momentum. That momentum supports moment-to-moment mindfulness during sitting meditation, allowing the practice to become deeper and more powerful. This is why the Buddha advised us to practice mindfulness all the time.

Throughout the day, we experience many feelings. How can we respond to them without being caught in clinging, and learn to let go?

Normally, when we experience feeling, desire follows. As meditators, however, we learn to see how feeling arises, how it passes away, the pleasure it offers, the danger it presents,

and how to let go of attachment to it. These are the five things we have to understand about feeling.

Feeling may be pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Each of these can be related to material sense pleasures or to spiritual practice. Happiness related to sense pleasures is a material feeling. When the pleasure disappears, we feel pain. Neutral feelings, too, can be related to sense pleasures. There are also feelings connected with spiritual practice: pleasure, pain, and neutral feeling.

We are all familiar with feelings related to sense pleasures. But what is spiritual pleasure? When we see that everything is impermanent, unsatisfactory, and without self, we are happy to see reality. That happiness is spiritual pleasure.

Spiritual pain can arise even when you see things as they really are and follow the meditation instructions diligently. You have not yet attained the goal, even the first stage of enlightenment, called stream-entry. Then you hear that someone who has followed the same practice has attained it much more quickly. You feel disappointed: “Even though I practice diligently, I have not attained this stage. How and when can I attain it?” This gives rise to spiritual urgency. It, too, arises from dukkha, suffering or unhappiness, but it has nothing to do with gaining material things.

With spiritual equanimity, you see things exactly as they are, without excitement or disappointment. This equanimity is not related to material things. It comes from seeing the nature of Dhamma, the true nature of everything.

If you reach this state of spiritual equanimity, you will not become attached to any feeling. Begin by seeing that whatever feeling you experience—pleasant, unpleasant, or

neutral—is impermanent. Seeing this, you become detached or dispassionate toward feeling. This is how we let go of attachment: by seeing reality.

How should we handle neutral mental formations, such as thoughts about computer work, planning, working with algorithms, or solving a problem? They do not seem particularly positive or negative, but they can proliferate too.

Mental formations fall into three categories: pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral. Neutral mental formations arise from neutral feeling. They share the same nature as other mental formations: they have a beginning and an end.

The mind keeps talking to itself, carrying on an inner conversation. Whether the thoughts are neutral or not, they interrupt concentration, so we have to learn to deal with them.

Planning for the future, doing mathematics, or thinking about scientific research may be neutral, but such thoughts will not help you gain concentration. During meditation, you need to set them aside temporarily and focus the mind on your practice.

When you return to daily activities, you cannot meditate as intensely. Even then, however, you can remain mindful and keep the mind from being invaded by greed, hatred, and delusion.

Can contemplating the elements in daily life help us move toward enlightenment?

Yes. The Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta and the Mahāsatipaṭṭhāna Sutta mention the four physical elements. We can also contemplate a group of eighteen elements. For each of the six senses, there are three: the sense itself, its object, and the corresponding consciousness. For example, there are the eye, the visible object, and eye-consciousness. Six groups of three make eighteen elements.

Mindfulness of the four elements is the basic practice. We use it to realize that these elements are free from self: “The earth, water, air, and fire elements are not mine. I am not them. They are not myself.”

Keep reminding yourself of this. Then you can explore the eighteen elements in greater detail. This contemplation is possible in daily life because it involves thinking about the elements.

When we stare at something, are we experiencing a series of eye contacts in quick succession?

You do not have to stare at something for eye contact to occur. Staring makes the eyes tired and can become painful. The moment you open your eyes, objects come into view. They do not literally touch your eyes; the contact is extremely subtle and difficult to illustrate.

When sunlight falls on an object, we say that the light makes contact with it. We do not mean that the sun itself strikes the object like a meteor. Similarly, when you open your eyes and focus on an object in front of you, consciousness of that object arises.

There may be thousands of other objects, but we are not conscious of all of them until we turn our attention to them. Consciousness arises in a split second. These things happen almost simultaneously, so quickly that we cannot separate them into a sequence of moments. This is what we call contact.

When we hear a sound, sound waves strike the eardrum and produce vibrations. The brain interprets these vibrations as songs, birdsong, or human speech, including the voices of boys and girls. The different meanings arise through the functioning of the

brain, but first there is the vibration of the sound waves. That initial vibration is what we call ear contact.

Similarly, molecules from food, perfume, and other things reach the sensitive part of the nose, and we smell them. As soon as they make contact, we know the smell. Nose contact, body contact, and the other forms of sense contact are very subtle encounters between the senses and their objects.

Without attention, that consciousness does not arise. For example, if you pay no attention to the questions being asked or to my answers, you do not experience that combination as ear contact, and you do not know what is happening.

Pay attention and remain aware of what is happening. The different aspects of this experience work together so quickly that you cannot isolate them.

Conclusion

Continuing the Practice



Friends, the sixteen instructions bring us back to the experience of breathing. Through it, we learn about the body, feeling, the mind, and the changing phenomena we experience. Calm and understanding develop together. As we see things arise, fade, and cease, we learn to let go. The purpose is freedom from suffering.

The sixteen steps form a connected training. What begins with knowing the breath becomes a way of understanding our experience more fully. We become familiar with the body and the feelings that arise, and learn to recognize the condition of the mind. We discover what disturbs it and what helps it become glad, steady, and free. This growing familiarity supports our contemplation of impermanence and our willingness to relinquish attachment. We learn the meaning of the instructions by practicing them.

For this training to develop, we have to make room for it in our lives. Sit regularly and give the practice your care. When a hindrance arises, recognize it without becoming angry with yourself. Notice what feeds it and use the appropriate means to let it go. Confidence encourages us to continue, while wisdom helps us examine our experience. Energy sustains our effort, and concentration steadies the mind. Mindfulness helps us recognize when these qualities are out of balance. We learn to enliven a dull mind and calm a restless one.

As the mind settles, we can see more clearly. Yet a peaceful sitting does not mean that all the roots of suffering have been removed. Concentration gives the mind stability, and insight reveals the changing nature of what we experience. These two aspects of practice support one another. Even when joy and deep calm arise, remain mindful. Notice any wish to hold on to them or to demand that the next sitting be the same.

We also learn to look closely at conditions. An experience does not arise by itself. We examine what supports it as well as how it arises and passes away. This applies to the body and to the mental processes we have studied throughout the book. In our own experience, we can recognize how contact gives rise to feeling and how craving and clinging sustain suffering. Understanding these relationships helps us see where we are feeding our difficulties and where we can begin to let go.

The contemplation of impermanence becomes personal when we see how readily we call these changing experiences “I” and “mine.” We want pleasure to remain, pain to disappear, and the body and mind to obey our wishes. Careful observation shows us the suffering in that attachment. As understanding deepens, we learn to loosen our grasp. The final direction of the sixteen steps—toward fading, cessation, and relinquishment—gives purpose to the whole training.

This is also how mindfulness of breathing supports awakening. Through the four foundations of mindfulness, the seven awakening factors develop together. Mindfulness and investigation help us understand; energy and joy sustain the work; tranquility, concentration, and equanimity allow the mind to remain settled and balanced. We cultivate these qualities with the intention to relinquish attachment. Their fulfillment is knowledge and liberation.

The practice continues when we get up from meditation. In conversation, listen carefully and notice the intention behind your reply. When anger arises, recognize it before allowing it to guide your speech. Let loving-friendliness inform how you treat others and how you respond to your own difficulties. The understanding gained in meditation can help us meet ordinary life with greater patience and kindness.

Use the instructions in the appendix to recall the practice. As you read, ask yourself what you can recognize in your own experience. Then return to the breath with patience and clear attention. Understanding develops through repeated practice. Give it time, and keep the purpose of the training in mind. May your practice bring peace to you and to all those whose lives you touch.

Appendix

The Sixteen Steps in Review

The sixteen instructions of the Ānāpānasati Sutta are presented below in Pali and English, arranged in four groups of four.¹¹⁰

Mindfulness of the Body

1 Long Breathing

Dīghaṃ vā assasanto ‘dīghaṃ assasāmī’ti pajānāti.

Breathing in long, he understands, “I breathe in long.”

dīghaṃ vā passasanto ‘dīghaṃ passasāmī’ti pajānāti.

Or breathing out long, he understands, “I breathe out long.”

2 Short Breathing

rassaṃ vā assasanto ‘rassaṃ assasāmī’ti pajānāti.

Breathing in short, he understands, “I breathe in short.”

rassaṃ vā passasanto ‘rassaṃ passasāmī’ti pajānāti.

Or breathing out short, he understands, “I breathe out short.”

3 The Whole Body of Breath

‘sabbakāyapaṭisaṃvedī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing the whole body of breath.”

‘sabbakāyapaṭisaṃvedī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out experiencing the whole body of breath.”

4 Tranquilizing the Bodily Formations

‘passambhayaṃ kāyasaṅkhāraṃ assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in tranquilizing the bodily formations.”

‘passambhayaṃ kāyasaṅkhāraṃ passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out tranquilizing the bodily formations.”

¹¹⁰ The English instructions are adapted from MN 118, §§18–21, in Ñāṇamoli and Bodhi, *The Middle Length Discourses of the Buddha*, and follow the wording used in this book. These paragraphs contain the sixteen instructions; the complete discourse is MN 118.

Mindfulness of Feeling

5 Experiencing Rapture

‘Pītipaṭisaṃvedī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing rapture.”

‘pītipaṭisaṃvedī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out experiencing rapture.”

6 Experiencing Pleasure

‘sukhapaṭisaṃvedī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing pleasure.”

‘sukhapaṭisaṃvedī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out experiencing pleasure.”

7 Experiencing Mental Formations

‘cittasaṅkhārapaṭisaṃvedī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing mental formations.”

‘cittasaṅkhārapaṭisaṃvedī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out experiencing the mental formations.”

8 Tranquilizing the Mental Formations

‘passambhayaṃ cittasaṅkhāraṃ assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in tranquilizing the mental formations.”

‘passambhayaṃ cittasaṅkhāraṃ passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out tranquilizing the mental formations.”

Mindfulness of Mind

9 Experiencing the Mind

‘Cittapaṭisaṁvedī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in experiencing the mind.”

‘cittapaṭisaṁvedī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out experiencing the mind.”

10 Gladdening the Mind

‘abhippamodayaṁ cittaṁ assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in gladdening the mind.”

‘abhippamodayaṁ cittaṁ passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out gladdening the mind.”

11 Concentrating the Mind

‘samādahaṁ cittaṁ assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in concentrating the mind.”

‘samādahaṁ cittaṁ passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out concentrating the mind.”

12 Liberating the Mind

‘vimocayaṁ cittaṁ assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in liberating the mind.”

‘vimocayaṁ cittaṁ passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out liberating the mind.”

Mindfulness of Dhamma

13 Contemplating Impermanence

‘Aniccānupassī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in contemplating impermanence.”

‘aniccānupassī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out contemplating impermanence.”

14 Contemplating Fading Away

‘virāgānupassī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in contemplating fading away.”

‘virāgānupassī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out contemplating fading away.”

15 Contemplating Cessation

‘nirodhānupassī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in contemplating cessation.”

‘nirodhānupassī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out contemplating cessation.”

16 Contemplating Relinquishment

‘paṭinissaggānupassī assasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe in contemplating relinquishment.”

‘paṭinissaggānupassī passasissāmī’ti sikkhati.

He trains thus: “I shall breathe out contemplating relinquishment.”

Pali text: Majjhima Nikāya 118.18–21, Mahāsaṅgīti edition.

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Canonical References

DN stands for Dīgha Nikāya, the collection of long discourses, and MN for Majjhima Nikāya, the collection of middle-length discourses. Khp stands for Khuddakapāṭha, the collection of short passages, and Sn for Sutta Nipāta, the collection of discourses. Dhammapada is a collection of verses; Theragāthā collects the verses of elder monks. Collection and discourse or verse numbers provide stable locators; English titles can vary between translations.

SN stands for Saṃyutta Nikāya, the connected discourses, and AN for Aṅguttara Nikāya, the numerical discourses. MN paragraph numbers refer to Bhikkhu Ñāṇamoli and Bhikkhu Bodhi’s translation. References to SN and AN identify the discourses in Bhikkhu Bodhi’s translations. Some quoted instructions include explanatory adaptations used in this book; the citations identify the corresponding canonical passages.

DN 1, Brahmajāla Sutta, The All-Embracing Net of Views.

DN 16, Mahāparinibbāna Sutta, The Great Discourse on the Buddha’s Passing.

DN 22, Mahā Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, The Great Discourse on the Foundations of Mindfulness.

MN 10, Satipaṭṭhāna Sutta, The Foundations of Mindfulness.

MN 19, Dvedhāvitakka Sutta, Two Kinds of Thought.

MN 20, Vitakkasaṇṭhāna Sutta, The Removal of Distracting Thoughts.

MN 28, Mahāhatthipadopama Sutta, The Greater Discourse on the Simile of the Elephant’s Footprint.

MN 44, Cūḷavedalla Sutta, The Shorter Series of Questions and Answers.

MN 62, Mahārāhulovāda Sutta, The Greater Discourse of Advice to Rāhula.

MN 115, Bahudhātuka Sutta, The Many Kinds of Elements.

MN 117, Mahācattārīsaka Sutta, The Great Forty.

MN 118, Ānāpānasati Sutta, Mindfulness of Breathing.
MN 119, Kāyagatāsati Sutta, Mindfulness of the Body.
MN 137, Saḷāyatanaṭṭhapaṇṇāsa Sutta, The Exposition of the Sixfold Base.
MN 148, Chachakka Sutta, The Six Sextets.
MN 152, Indriyabhāvanā Sutta, The Development of the Faculties.
SN 2.26, Rohitassa Sutta, To Rohitassa.
SN 12.2, Paṭiccasamuppādaṭṭhapaṇṇāsa Sutta, Analysis of Dependent Co-arising.
SN 12.11, Āhāra Sutta, Nutriment.
SN 36.23, Bhikkhu Sutta, To a Certain Bhikkhu.
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SN 46.51, Āhāra Sutta, Nutriment.
SN 46.53, Aggi Sutta, Fire.
SN 48.10, Indriyavibhaṅga Sutta, Analysis of the Mental Faculties.
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SN 54.7, Kappina Sutta, Kappina.
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AN 1.48, Lahuparivatta Sutta, Quick to Reverse Itself.
AN 4.41, Samādhi Sutta, Concentration.
AN 4.45, Rohitassa Sutta, To Rohitassa.
AN 6.55, Soṇa Sutta, Soṇa.
AN 10.58, Mūla Sutta, Rooted.
Itivuttaka 44, Nibbānadhātu Sutta, The Nibbāna Element.
Khp 9, Karaṇīyamettā Sutta; also Sn 1.8, verses 143–52.
Dhammapada 34, in chapter 3, Cittavagga, The Mind.
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